Vegan FAQ

Answering common questions about veganism

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Introduction

Welcome to Vegan FAQ

Vegan FAQ has a simple purpose: to list answers to common questions or comments vegans get when people discover they are vegan.

As someone who has had to answer these common questions a lot, I thought it might be useful to pen down some of my reflections on these. Each question has a quick, snappy answer, along with a longer, in-depth answer that might even get a little philosophical. Read them in order, or just read the ones you are interested in; it's up to you.

Origins

Anyone who has been vegan for a long time will have witnessed a lot of positive change in the world. There are more vegan options in restaurants, more vegan products in the shops, and the products are often of a better quality. Vegan cheese in particular has come a long way since the early 2000s. While veganism has never been more widespread in mainstream consciousness, actual vegans are still a relatively niche part of the general population. A lot more people have now heard of veganism, but they still don't know much about it, certainly the philosophical side of it. What this means is that when someone finds out you are a vegan, they will ask you questions, and after a while, you will notice these start to become familiar questions.

As a way to have fun with this reality, someone once sent me a meme called Defensive Omnivore Bingo, where you would tick off a square when you heard the same old conversational points. Inspired by this, I decided to make an interactive phone application called Vegan Bingo. I must admit at the time, I didn't have a good idea of how the game of Bingo really worked, but the application was downloaded by hundreds of people and got some good reviews. This inspired me to make the website https://veganbingo.net, which works on all devices. After a rewrite of Vegan Bingo, I decided I would turn it into a book as well, and thus Vegan FAQ was let loose on the world.

Being vegan in a non-vegan world

Personally, I've been through various stages of dealing with being vegan in a non-vegan world. As a new vegan, I was full of naive hope; I thought that we just needed to tell people about the reality of animal suffering in our farming systems and in nature, and they would start to change their behaviours. This was inevitably followed by disillusionment with the fact that people didn't have any good argument for eating animals, but that didn't stop them from stubbornly defending it. I've reached a point in a discussion about eating animals where the person said, "We are human, and they are not", which is a classification, not an argument. There is a point where rationality fails, and you realise people don't even care that their reasons aren't very good ones. They are on the majority side, and that is enough.

Many say they love animals. Given the amount of suffering involved in animal agriculture, with many billions of animals in it every year, you would think people who love animals would be highly concerned about the ethics of the system. Talking to someone who eats meat for a few minutes, however, often shows this not to be the case. They often don't know the basics of animal agriculture, but in an example of the Dunning-Kruger phenomenon, they have no idea that they don't know. If you ask them a basic question about factory farming, they will give you a poor answer, instantly refutable by two minutes on the internet. They aren't happy if you inform them or correct them about anything, though; rather, they get annoyed at you for bringing to their attention the needless suffering of billions of animals, suffering they are directly contributing to. I have a simple proposition for people - Don’t ask me where I get my protein from if you don’t care about my answer and are just clumsily trying to justify your own apathy and inaction towards animal suffering

Now that I've been vegan for a long time, I've come to what I think is a healthier and more productive relationship with the non-vegan world. When people ask me questions, even stupid loaded questions, I see it as an invitation to advocate for the animals. I don't expect that I am going to change anyone's mind in a single conversation, so I concentrate on trying to open a crack in their perception, one that eventually widens enough that they can properly see the suffering of animals. Everyone has to go through various stages of truth, and at some point, most ideas are new to everybody, especially ideas that are deliberately hidden in the culture. My own truth is also incomplete, so I try to listen to people and their stories, and remember there is often something I can learn from them. I ate animal products for the first 29 years of my life. I probably would have had the same questions and said the same things to justify my own unexamined habits. So I imagine myself in their place, lowering my expectations for what I am likely to achieve, but also raising my aim from a single person to a culture. If I can remove one or two of a person's barriers to change, and at least avoid creating more barriers by giving them a bad experience of conversing about veganism, that is probably enough. I want to leave people more open to discussing veganism, as I have found them. If next time they meet a vegan, see vegan products, or see something about a new documentary exposing animal farming, I want them to be more, not less, likely to engage after having met me.

Keeping the focus

Veganism is about our society's shared moral progress. Hopefully, we can bring people along on this journey, and that starts by assuming other people are also trying to figure out how to live well and ethically in this world, just like we are. Some people may just argue out of ego and social status, or they like conforming and just don't want to change, or maybe they don’t really have any higher ideals beyond selfishness, but it's not really easy to tell what sort of person we are talking to, whether they are open to change or not. Just because someone argues with us doesn't mean they are against veganism. Some argue rigorously and perceptively, because they want proof of a position before they consider adopting it. People don’t change lightly after all, nor should they. We should accept and even encourage that. Our job is to be part of people's journeys, to at least plant seeds of helping people see a truth that they might come to be thankful for.

We can keep making progress towards a vegan world, but it is going to take the same thoughtfulness, energy and activism as it has taken to remove other horrors of our past. Vegan FAQ is an attempt to positively affect the cultural conversation from which that change can happen. Hope you get something out of it!

If you'd like to get in touch about veganism or anything else, or just want to read my thoughts, check out my web page at: https://camerongreen.org. You can also check out the Vegan Bingo website at https://veganbingo.net.

Ahimsa!

Cameron

1. Protein

Question

Where do you get protein?

Alternatives

Where do you get iron? What about some obscure trace element (that they didn’t know about 2 months ago)?

Summary

When you mention you are vegan, many people suddenly become very interested in your nutritional requirements. Unfortunately, common knowledge hasn't caught up with the fact that most nutrients, including protein, originally come from plants. There are no essential nutrients that humans need that can only be derived from animal products, and the peak nutritional bodies affirm that a well-planned plant-based diet is healthy for all life stages. Healthy vegans don’t just remove things from their diet; they add other nutrient-rich foods in their place. By doing this, you can optimise your health while reducing your contribution to animal suffering and environmental destruction.

Discussion

At a party many years ago, a boy of roughly 10 brought around a plate of snacks. I declined the offerings but mentioned I’d be interested if there were any vegan ones. He then promptly asked me where I got my protein from. I'd heard this question many times before, but something about his young age and the speed with which he asked this question took me aback. When an exact repeated statement is so prevalent in culture that it is imprinted in the heads of children, we should wonder how it got there.

As a vegan, my doctor has never asked me about my protein intake, for good reason. Protein deficiency is extremely rare in wealthy countries. People with a diverse and adequate caloric diet, vegan or otherwise, easily obtain the recommended amounts of protein. Protein is in a lot of foods, so we get portions of it all the time. Even if someone ate nothing but potatoes, so long as they ate enough to maintain their overall weight, they would come very close to meeting their daily protein requirements. So why are non-vegans obsessed with protein above the myriad other things that people need to be healthy? B12, for instance, is harder to get on plant-based diets, so vegans need to know about supplementing their B12. Vegans are rarely asked about B12, however, or anything else similarly well-informed; instead, we get asked over and over again about protein.

Plant protein primer

Despite the concern around how much protein vegans are getting, the people who ask about protein rarely know how much we need or how much is actually in different plant foods. There’s no shame in not knowing everything about nutrition; we aren’t born knowing such things, but it would seem reasonable to investigate a little before you criticise a particular diet or dole out nutritional advice.

How much protein you need changes according to a number of factors, such as life stage and your fitness goals. Recommended daily intake ranges from 0.75 grams of protein per kilo of bodyweight to up to 2 grams for elite athletes. Most dietary bodies have public guidelines you can follow, and you should consult a qualified nutritionist. Once you have a daily target for your protein intake, it's worth checking your current diet to see how much you are already eating. A food diary kept over a couple of representative weeks that can be checked against a nutrition database will give you a world of information about your intake of protein and other nutrients. Everyone should probably do this every few years to improve their diet.

There is the concept of complete and incomplete proteins. The body produces most of the amino acids we need; however, there are a number we need to get from our diet. An ingredient is considered a complete or perfect protein if it contains all of the necessary amino acids in it. Complete proteins include animal products but also soy, quinoa, amaranth, hemp, chia, and buckwheat. Then there are incomplete proteins, foods which contain a subset of the necessary amino acids, and good sources of these include nuts, legumes and wholegrains. It was once thought that if you were eating incomplete proteins, it was necessary to combine the right ones so that your meal would form a complete protein. The classic examples would be beans and rice, or bread and hummus, which together form a complete protein. Current research says that the body is smart enough to do this on its own, and as long as you eat a variety of whole foods, you will be fine. Eating more quinoa won't hurt, though!

For those who need to increase the protein in their diet, there are also protein powders, of which a variety are plant-based. These are commonly available and similarly priced to other protein powders. Many are based on rice, soy, pea, or hemp protein, though the variety is quite wide. Some of them use blends for those wanting to get a specific protein profile. Again, though, your body is smart enough to combine things, so if you are eating plenty of rice, you will be better off eating a legume-based protein powder.

The proof of the ability to get protein on a vegan diet is in the fact that many high-profile athletes, including Olympians, weightlifters and bodybuilders, follow a vegan diet. Olympic gold medallist Carl Lewis changed to a vegan diet at 30, after which he achieved all of his personal bests, including setting the world record in the 100 metres of 9.86 seconds. Clearly, many elite athletes are getting what their bodies need for peak performance from a vegan diet. Nearly all of them also regularly consult nutritional professionals to make sure their diets meet their specific needs. We can all emulate these elite athletes and eat healthier diets that match our fitness goals while being kinder to animals and the planet.

Sexual politics

A hint as to where the protein question derives from is the gender of the people who usually ask about it. Many men obsess about their masculinity, which they relate to strength and muscle, and a single nutrient, protein. Protein, though, isn't the only thing required in the

complex process of building muscle. We need enough calories to drive the growth process, fats to produce hormones, and carbohydrates to maintain energy levels. Still, few people ask vegans if we are getting the right mix of healthy fats; it is almost always about protein.

The masculine aspects of killing animals and eating meat have a long history in the human psyche. Most forager societies had gendered tendencies around the division of labour, with men taking on more hunting tasks, especially of larger animals. Men tend to be larger, stronger, and more expendable from an evolutionary perspective, so they were more suitable for dangerous tasks. Bringing in a large animal could give one status within the tribe, so while men focused more on this high-status task, it will come as little surprise that studies show that most diets in the Palaeolithic era were heavily plant-based.

The association between masculinity and violent killing, like many of our evolutionary tendencies, has been ripe for exploitation by the marketing industry. There has been a sustained and well-funded marketing effort to tighten the association between masculinity and meat-eating. Typical of this from my own childhood were the high-rotation meat industry advertisements on 1980s Australian television. The ad's focus was on a sports jersey-clad young boy. He runs into his family dining room, where his father reads a newspaper while sitting at the table with the boy's sister. The mother emerges from the kitchen with the burned, severed leg of an animal on a dish. There is no subtlety about the stereotypes or messaging here, or any thought to the diet of the women in the ad; the tagline is "Feed the man meat". These ads are reinforcing a widely held view in society. Studies have shown that even female vegetarians view men who abstain from meat as more feminine (though they omit to mention whether the women thought that was a good thing). There is inarguably a sexual politics to meat consumption. Masculinity is aligned with killing; the more toxic masculinity, the more it celebrates and reinforces this alignment. Women tend to eat less meat, the majority of vegans are women, and women generally hold more pro-social views. Instead of clinging to their masculine identity like a security blanket, if many men could free themselves of it, we would progress a little faster to a better world. It was those who tended to gather rather than hunt who had things right all along.

Corporate propaganda

Decent people don't want to participate in cruelty. To make them do so, the cruelty must be mostly hidden, or they must be convinced that it is necessary. Meat and dairy industry propaganda reaches far more people than unbiased nutritional advice. The industry has long used its financial and political sway to ensure a dominant voice on government nutritional panels and has been repeatedly successful in watering down attempts to make national eating guidelines healthier. They maintain this propaganda war because nutritional science often contradicts perceived national and regional financial self-interest. Not only do we not need to eat animals, but some of the most highly profitable forms of animal products that governments help promote are actively unhealthy. The International Agency for Research on Cancer, a part of the World Health Organisation, has listed processed meats like bacon as a known cancer risk, and red meat generally as a probable cancer risk.

National eating guidelines have been very slow to recognise plant-based sources of protein, such as lentils, one of the first crops ever domesticated, or tofu, which has been part of the Asian diet for at least two thousand years. This long-overdue change in guidelines is starting to happen because authorities are increasingly being asked to respond to science and human health rather than to economic interests. That this change has correlated with fewer purely

patriarchal governments and more women in positions of power generally is unlikely to be purely coincidental. We can not take this improvement for humans and animals for granted, however, as it is under constant assault from the entrenched interests of the animal product industry.

Science and plant-based diets

The modern scientific understanding of dietitians about plant-based diets has been slow to filter outwards, even in the wider medical community. I've had an elite cardiologist ask me where I get my protein from, and I know many people who have heard similarly poorly informed things from doctors and medical specialists. Unfortunately, most medical professionals only receive elementary nutritional training and are as susceptible to the unquestioned and outdated ideas cluttering up our culture as everyone else. One study found that doctors in the US and UK received about 11 hours of nutritional training during their five to eight year degrees. If we look at the opinions about plant-based diets from professionals who have completed an in-depth study of nutrition in their degrees, dietitians, we usually see a very different story. The public stances of peak nutritional bodies around the world generally state similar things to the following position of the Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics:

"Appropriately planned vegetarian diets, including total vegetarian or vegan diets, are healthful, nutritionally adequate, and may provide health benefits in the prevention and treatment of certain diseases. Well-planned vegetarian diets are appropriate for individuals during all stages of the life cycle, including pregnancy, lactation, infancy, childhood, and adolescence, and for athletes."

For vegans, there is an important point here we shouldn't ignore. Vegans need to take note of the words “appropriately planned” in the Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics quote above. The idea that vegan diets are innately healthy is almost as ill-informed as the idea that they are innately unhealthy. Vegan diets aren’t a magic bullet. Like all diets, they can be unhealthy if they contain too much sugar, oil, fat and fried food, and don't contain enough fruits, vegetables, pulses and whole grains. Perhaps the easiest test of the healthiness of a vegan diet is how regularly they include whole beans and lentils. A vegan diet is different to the diet most people in our modern world grew up with, so there might be some learning and adjustment needed. This is particularly true for people who grew up in a family that followed a meat-centric diet or one high in highly processed foods. They may need to learn how to cook in a healthier way, or perhaps even learn to cook period. A healthy vegan diet isn't one in which animal products are simply removed, but one in which they are replaced with plant-derived alternatives. There is a whole world of ingredients vegans and non-vegans should be more familiar with, particularly the incredible variety of beans and legumes that have been staples of human cultures for so long.

Vegans who eat a whole foods, plant-based diet don’t need to worry much about things people who eat too much meat and processed foods struggle with, such as fibre, antioxidants, healthy fats, vitamin C and the other goodies that fruits, vegetables and plant protein sources are loaded with. Instead, people on plant-based diets should keep an eye on having adequate sources of things like calcium, vitamin D, and omega-3s, and of course, B12, which they should supplement.

In the end, we should be getting our nutritional advice from qualified dietitians, not friends, family, random people, social media or even what you are reading now. A great investment in

improving your health is booking a couple of sessions with a university-qualified nutritionist who understands plant-based diets. They will help you ensure your diet is working towards your long-term life goals. People can become overly obsessed with food, so it's not about purity, but getting the core of your diet right will serve you well for life.

Healthy food is a gift we can give ourselves and others that will help maintain physical and mental health. It will also reverberate positively out into the world. As a quote attributed to Hippocrates says, "Let thy food be thy medicine". Let us follow this advice while also ensuring our food is kinder to animals and the environment.

2. Cheese

Question

I could never give up cheese

Alternatives

I could never go vegan because... but you won't need any other alternative because you'll be hearing about cheese repeatedly.

Summary

Cheese is mostly about two things: fat and cruelty to animals. By giving up cheese, you will reduce both your fat intake and your contribution to suffering. More than other animal products, it is common for people to say they feel better after giving up dairy. This is unsurprising, as, like all other mammals, humans are naturally weaned from their mother's milk after infancy. Only a third of people globally have the genetic mutation necessary to process lactose beyond infancy. The experience of expressing and imbibing milk evolved as part of the intimate relationship between a mother and her child. For humans to interfere in this relationship, to commercialise the pregnancies of other species, is oppressive...and slightly weird and creepy.

Discussion

The statement "I could never give up cheese" implies an unspoken corollary: "I don't care what cruelty or environmental destruction is involved in producing it". Hopefully, most people are better than this, and there is a line of cruelty towards animals that they would not cross. Would many people really continue drinking dairy if they became convinced it was both unnecessary and intolerably cruel? Assuming they can become informed about this, we would hope that people could find enough self-control and compassion for other species to make a positive change.

The problem is that few people who drink dairy know, or wish to know, the truth behind the industry. If they educated themselves about the bereaved mothers, stolen calves, swollen udders, mastitis, castration, confinement, veal production, contribution to antibiotic resistance, human health problems and environmental degradation associated with dairy, it would be easier for them to find the moral courage to make the change from dairy to any of the many alternatives.

Milking them for all they are worth

To turn cows, who are sensitive and caring mothers, into milk machines requires regular cruelty.

Some of the cruellest parts of the dairy industry stem from milk and pregnancy being intertwined. Cows, like humans and other mammals, will produce milk only due to pregnancy. As soon as cows are able to bear calves, they begin a cycle of annual impregnation. This is to keep milk production high, as it would naturally slow ten months after pregnancy. Over their milk-producing life, a cow will be milked continually, except for a two-month "dry period" before each calf is born. The majority of cows will be impregnated artificially, via a device wielded by a farm hand. Traditionally, and still practised in many places, cows will be impregnated on something the industry calls "the rape rack": a device on which cows are restrained to be mounted by a bull. Before modern methods of sexual selection, half of the calves born would be male, creating vast numbers of unwanted, less profitable calves. Today, it is more common to inseminate dairy cows with semen from beef-specific breeds. This keeps milk production high while producing offspring that can be profitably sold for slaughter. Farmers separate calves from their mothers, usually within 12 to 24 hours of birth. This ensures the calves don't drink their mother's valuable milk and tries to minimise the development of a maternal bond between the mother and child. The pain of the separation between cow and calf is well documented in heartbreaking footage accessible online. They show distraught cows running behind vehicles that are taking, probably yet another, calf away from them. One can hear the emotion in both mother and child as they vocalise the pain and grief of their separation. Perhaps it should be legislated that this sound is played when one opens a bottle of milk or a packet of cheese.

Unwanted male dairy calves, sometimes called "Bobby" calves, are often funnelled into the veal trade. Female calves also can be destined for this fate if a farm has more cows than it needs to reproduce their herd, or if market conditions make it especially profitable. As dairy breeds are slowly growing and less muscular than beef breeds, it is unprofitable to raise them to adulthood, so they are slaughtered as calves for veal. Veal calves were once raised in narrow, solitary crates to ensure they got minimal exercise, though to achieve this end, they are now more commonly raised in group sheds. They are given a controlled diet, often low in iron, to ensure their flesh doesn't toughen and become pink. Instead of their mother's milk, they are fed on formulas partly composed of whey protein, a waste product from cheese production. Veal calves are then slaughtered at ages ranging from just days to, more rarely, a few months old. Calves not destined for the veal trade will be slaughtered for uses such as leather or pet food and other low-grade meat.

If not surplus to milk production requirements, female calves will go on to join their unfortunate mothers in the cycle of suffering and death that results from life as a milk and calf production machine. They will endure having their horns removed (debudding) without anaesthetic, mastitis from over-milking, annual pregnancies with calf separation, and lameness from living with oversized udders that are the result of generations of selective breeding to produce ever more milk. This will all end in transport to a slaughterhouse, often itself an ordeal that involves being starved and dehydrated to make slaughter cleaner. It's strange how often people will say, "You don't have to kill cows to get dairy". Yet more evidence of the disconnect with the reality of animal farming systems. Every cow, beef or dairy, is destined, while still relatively young, for the horrors of slaughter. After a life of intensive calf and milk production, cows are killed when their fertility drops and their production becomes less optimal, usually between four and seven years of age. Left alone, these intelligent animals would live three to five times longer, becoming matriarchs and important members of their communities.

Dairy's long shadow

Apart from routine animal cruelty, the dairy industry is also among the most environmentally destructive industries on our planet.

Dairy is a major contributor to deforestation, species extinction, air pollution, water consumption, water pollution, and greenhouse gas emissions. As outlined in the landmark Poore & Nemecek (2018) study, dairy milk production uses ten times as much land, produces three times as many greenhouse gas emissions, and consumes twenty times more fresh water than equivalent plant-based milks. Dairy utilises not only the land on which cows graze, but also massive areas of cropland to produce their feed. The vast quantities of manure and urine produced by the dairy industry globally run into water and soil systems. This triggers eutrophication - with the excess of nutrients causing, among other things, algal blooms that reduce oxygen in water systems and lead to mass fish kills and dead zones. The dairy industry rarely pays the cost for its negative effects on the environment, but it outsources those costs to governments and communities. Just grabbing a different carton from the supermarket shelf can drastically improve not only your ethical but also your environmental footprint.

Many people will have heard of the Antibiotic Resistance Crisis, which is threatening to undermine one of the pillars of our modern health system. What many people don't know is that animal agriculture uses over two-thirds of antibiotics globally, often fed as a precaution to healthy animals. Due to the mastitis caused by over-milking via machines, the dairy industry is a major user of antibiotics globally. Livestock animals do not consume all of the antibiotics they are fed; instead, the excess is washed into the environment along with their urine and manure. This environmental contamination creates a perfect evolutionary breeding ground for antibiotic-resistant 'superbugs', posing a severe, systemic threat to both animal and human health.

Necessary?

Given the negative impacts of dairy corporations on animals and the environment, how vital are they to feeding our global population?

Only about a third of people worldwide have the genetic mutation necessary to process dairy. Strangely, not having this mutation is often called lactose malabsorption, which makes it sound like a condition some people have, when it is actually our natural state. Humans are mammals, and mammals don't drink milk beyond early childhood; they are weaned off it by their mothers onto solid foods. This enables the child to be self-supporting and gives the mother's body a break from the costly biological function of producing milk, a phase of the reproductive cycle that consumes more of the mother's energy resources than even pregnancy. When mammals exit infancy and stop consuming milk, their bodies naturally reduce the production of the enzymes needed to process lactose.

The majority of humans throughout history have also followed the standard mammalian path. Thousands of years ago, however, in cattle-dependent regions of Europe and Africa, genetic mutations occurred that kept lactase, the lactose-digesting enzyme, active after childhood. That mutation, called lactase persistence, is still a minority in all large populations other than those of Northern and Western European descent. Even for people with the genetic mutation, this ability tends to degrade as we age. Due to the prevalence of dairy products in many foods, especially comfort and fast foods, people will often continue consuming dairy even though they

are unable to digest lactose. It is often not until people get a diagnosis or follow an exclusion diet that they figure out the cause of their digestive and other related problems. This is part of why people who give up dairy often report feeling better, even more so than those who give up other animal products.

Dairy is an acquired taste, a taste that will be lost over time. I can personally attest to this. I honestly thought I would not notice if I were accidentally served cow's milk in a coffee or other drink. I even said to friends, "It has probably happened, and I haven't noticed". On the rare occasions I have accidentally been served dairy, I have found I notice immediately, and that it has a very unpleasant taste compared to my regular plant milk. Dairy has a strange sort of musty, sour flavour, something that reminds you that cow's milk has pus in it, the levels of which are more elevated today because of the mastitis that cows' udders frequently get from milking machines. Even most dairy consumers don't seem to like that musty, sour flavour very much, as is evidenced by the highly processed, less flavourful cheeses and sugar-laden yoghurts that dominate markets. A good quality dairy alternative often tastes smoother and cleaner. Try oat milk in your coffee or beverages for a little while, and you won't want to go back.

Compassionate choices

Dairy is neither kind, sustainable, nor necessary. So how do we start moving beyond it?

Butter and cheese can be replaced by anything with some fat in it. Avocado is a common go-to for replacing them in sandwiches, burgers and salads. Depending on the dish you are preparing, there are numerous other options, such as various nut spreads, plant oils, tahini and countless variations of the amazingly versatile hummus. There are also plant-based versions of most dairy products that are getting better and more varied all the time, such as soft cashew cheeses, hard cheeses, cheddar-style slices, and even blue cheeses. Try asking for vegan mozzarella on your next pizza, and you probably won't notice much of a change at all. Milk is perhaps the queen of plant-based options. There are so many types to choose from, it is hard to keep up. Oat, hemp, almond, cashew, soy, rice, coconut and various blends of them are all popular, and they come in many styles such as light, creamy and specialised barista versions. You would have to be pretty determined not to find a plant-based milk that you like. Soy milk is probably the most nutritionally complete; oat milk is generally the people’s favourite for taste and texture; and almond milk is very popular too if you like a slightly nutty taste. Some people also like the richness of coconut milk, which can work well in sweet drinks and smoothies. For yoghurt and ice cream, there are also a vast number of alternatives, with coconut being very common, but try a few and figure out which ones are to your taste.

Are these alternatives all the same as the dairy products you've acquired a taste for? With a few exceptions, the answer is usually no. They are made from different things, so you may need to acquire a taste for them, just as you once did with dairy products. It's worth doing so for all the ethical reasons already outlined, and it is a positive change you can make at a very low cost to yourself.

There is a massive industry trying to keep you invested in dairy. Milk and dairy corporations are often huge, with major government support and subsidies. There is a whole deep dive you can do on the US Government Cheese programme: a vast stockpile which was partially responsible for cheese being so deeply embedded into the modern American diet. The marketing and lobbying power of the dairy industry reaches into our governments and homes

globally. National Dietary guidelines are regularly published by countries, and they affect what is served in prisons, schools, hospitals and the military, and feed into the public understanding of nutrition. Groups of well-funded animal-oppressing corporations and lobbying groups attend reviews on national dietary guidelines, with the dairy industry often being one of the biggest spenders amongst them. The dairy industry is also a major funder of academic research, which is vital to its interests, as studies funded by food corporations have been found to be between four and eight times more likely to have findings that align with their economic interests.

Be the change

Positive life changes can be hard, such as getting to bed earlier, exercising every day, keeping hydrated, being kind, being grateful, and keeping the ultra-wealthy from corrupting our political systems. We often know what we should do, but find it hard to find the motivation to follow through with it. Giving up dairy, though, is very low-hanging fruit with little personal cost. Why not take this quick win for compassion and the environment? When ordering coffee, it is literally as easy as adding one word like “oat” before your order, or maybe just asking your barista which plant-based milk they recommend. When shopping, just reach for a different part of the shelf where the milks all are. Try a pizza with vegan cheese, pine nuts, or just some extra splashes of olive oil. A little exploration, some often small changes in habits, and you won't look back.

Finally, this may be heresy to many vegans, but if cheese really is that much of a sticking point, then don’t make the perfect the enemy of the good. Start somewhere else. Make perhaps the easiest change of swapping to plant milk, or maybe you only order vegan cheese when you find it's pretty decent. Vegan cheese on pizzas is fine, and I have had many people try my vegan pizza, after which they almost always say, "If you didn't tell me, I wouldn't have noticed". Eating less dairy is a good start, especially for the animals, so don't create unnecessary barriers to positive change. Like breaking other habits, sometimes it helps to minimise the habit first, have a transitory phase, so the final break seems less of a change. Millions of other people like you have made this positive change and would never look back, so you can too. Don’t think of it as giving something up, but instead as living more truly to your higher self.

You can give up dairy; you can lean into your compassion; you can be a powerful force in helping to create a kinder world.

3. Cows

Question

Where would all the cows go?

Alternatives

What about all the farmers? What about the open landscapes of the countryside? Isn't soy destroying the Amazon?

Summary

Farm animals are not left to breed among themselves. It should come as no surprise that nothing is left to chance in the big business that is intensive animal farming. Breeding is strictly controlled and responds to the laws of supply and demand rather than the needs of animals or their welfare. If people eat fewer animals, livestock corporations will artificially breed fewer. It may be interesting to think about “what if we all suddenly stopped eating animals?” But, back in reality, the transition will probably continue to be gradual, and our economies will have plenty of time to adjust.

Discussion

When people try to justify why they eat animals, the main thing the conversation generally reveals is how divorced people are from the reality of modern industrial farming.

Animal agriculture today bears little resemblance to the way animals were kept on farms for most of human history. General knowledge appears to have advanced little beyond the children's book images of a cow called Daisy wearing a straw hat, the rooster on the fence greeting the sun, and the anthropomorphised pig, smiling while enjoying a grassy field. Certainly, these are the sort of images the livestock industry adorns its products with, but it is strange that adults would believe an industrial system with billions of animals in it is still anything like Old MacDonald’s farm.

Modern animal farms have thousands or even millions of a single gender and breed of animal, crowded into conditions where the only limit on cruelty is anything that might interfere with profits. Cruel ways of slaughtering animals are sometimes changed, not because they are cruel, but rather because they flood an animal's body with so many stress hormones that they are detectable in the final product. Chopping off tails, horns, beaks, and genitals is all routine and done without anaesthetic. Animals are taken from their families, fed alive into grinders, and experience regular horrors that are considered just part of the business. Except for vegans who don't contribute to the system, only a tiny minority of the public seems to care about any of this. The profits of animal agriculture corporations are heavily increased by the near-total apathy of many animal product consumers towards the lives of animals. Animal exploitation is

big business, run by vast corporations to maximise profits for owners and investors. This is a part of society where the slaughter of even more animals is something only to be celebrated. In this chain based on the oppression of other forms of life, extending from corporate executives to end consumers, only a vanishing few people involved will ever spend a moment to bear witness to, or even think about, the lives and deaths of the animals in the system they pay for and profit from.

Genetics, like everything else in an industrial factory farm, is highly controlled. The search for profits is evident in the manipulated bodies of livestock animals. Turkeys, for instance, have had their natural form so warped by selective breeding that not only are they unable to fly, but they are also incapable of breeding naturally and must be inseminated by humans. Many farm animals, after generations of selective breeding, live with bodies that outgrow the ability of their skeleton and internal organs to support them. No animal on these farms gets to live anything like a natural lifespan, but it is perhaps a mercy for many to be slaughtered at such a young age, rather than live with the painful bodily mutations we have bred into them. Animals on factory farms do not breed naturally at their own inclination; they are only brought into existence when we breed them. If breeding these animals were to become no longer profitable, the majority of them would disappear in less than a generation.

Ethical transitions

From the point of view of social change, it’s also not a well-thought-out question to ask what happens if industrial animal farming ends overnight, just because that’s rarely how improvements in the ethics of society happen. Some of the horrors of the past took decades and centuries of thought and movement building to change. Ideas often spread slowly in society, usually championed by small groups of committed individuals. Often, there comes a sudden change, a moment when a tipping point occurs. Legislation banning unethical practices is finally passed, and the social license of common consent for them is withdrawn. There may be many more vegans today than decades ago, but we are still a small minority. We are far from any position enabling us to widely legislate more humane farming, much less abolish animal farming.

Our animal product-consuming friends needn't worry. Sadly for animals, animal agriculture is not going to end tomorrow. They can give up animal products without the nightmare of factory farms empty of tortured animals, or of the killing floors of the slaughterhouses ceasing to be covered with the blood of innocents. They don't need to worry about the rewilding of nature, or of native animals and plants reclaiming the pastures that for millions of years prior to animal agriculture were their homes. Instead, we should be glad that the real nightmare will end, the horrific system that the eating of animals on an industrial scale has created in our world. We can say a long overdue goodbye to the hooks, cages, brands, barbed wire, whips, electric prods, slaughterhouses and countless other tools of animal oppression. It is not only nothing to fear, but the reduction of much fear caused by humanity in the world.

Crisis or progress?

As for what will happen to the jobs of the animal farmers, butchers, slaughterhouse workers and others in the livestock industry, that change will also happen gradually. People will transition to other work and products, just like so many changes in industries and technologies have happened in the past. New opportunities will be created because people will still need food and will still need to eat the same number of calories and nutrients. Those farmers and

businesses that succeed will be those best able to adapt to more animal-friendly foods. This change will also be better in the long run for the people involved in the cruelty of animal farming. If fewer poor people are living psychologically traumatising lives, spending their days stabbing, slaughtering and dissecting animals in sheds hidden away from the rest of society, then that's a win for animals and humans. People working in animal agriculture, especially in slaughterhouses, cannot do so without damaging some part of their psyche. We see this in higher rates of violence, trauma, intense shock, paranoia, anxiety, guilt and shame. These poor, often immigrant, workers, who are paid to do animal agriculture's dirty work, work that few of us would want to witness, much less do, will only be helped by transitioning to less violent work.

In the past, when society has legislated an end to cruel or outdated practices, transition plans have been put in place, including paying compensation. Nobles and owners were often compensated when serfs or slaves were freed. Although we think it strange and unjust for the state to pay out to people involved in what should always have been a criminal enterprise, it was deemed necessary for society to adapt and move forward at the time. Upton Sinclair once said it was hard to get a person to understand something if their salary depended on them not understanding it; we might expect the same about what they think their food depends on. Most people know on some level that factory farming is cruel, but as with other atrocities of the past, it might take some distance from it for people to comprehend the full horror of what they once tolerated.

As for all the open fields in the countryside, people may have grown accustomed to their current state, but it is cleared land that is more sterile and hostile to species than it has been for millions of years. If we watched the trees being felled in making these cleared spaces, and saw the native animals being killed or dispersed, we might think differently. It was once said about the Roman Empire that it created a desolation and called it peace. Something similar could be said about clearing complex forest ecosystems to create livestock pasture. We should think more deeply about what we are looking at when we pass a deforested pasture populated only by animals enclosed in barbed wire. We rarely think about the story of who and what lived on a land in both city and country before it was cleared for human development, and who the beings were who lived there before being killed, removed or dispossessed. The fields that have now been turned into monocultures of introduced species were once complex ecosystems, bustling with life in forms endless and beautiful. Ecosystems integrate millions of years of evolutionary wisdom in their subtle balance. In beginning the process of restoring them, we must hope that not all that deep wisdom has been irrevocably lost. At least some of the workers freed from animal production industries could find more meaningful and healing work rewilding the places we have so denuded, allowing the native flora and fauna to reclaim their ancient homes.

Rewilding

The benefits of rewilding the pastureland of our world would be many. Livestock farming and the crops grown to feed livestock cover a huge percentage of our globe. Environmental reports from the United Nations and other authorities have long said that livestock farming is one of the primary causes of environmental degradation. It is a leading cause of species extinction, deforestation, water pollution, air pollution and most other environmental problems. The monopolisation of land by the livestock industry is not just a cruelty done to non-humans. Much of the land of dispossessed poor and indigenous people over recent centuries has been usurped to farm high-profit livestock by privileged elites and colonisers. The already large carbon

footprint of livestock farming, quoted by bodies like the UN, usually does not include the carbon reduction we would all share by rewilding millions of acres of pasture and cropland currently dedicated to livestock and their feed. Other than our reliance on fossil fuels, there is no other consumption we engage in that competes with animal agriculture in terms of negative environmental and political impacts.

Persistent myths

While we touch on the environment, we must deal with something that has been said to vegans as long as I have been vegan: "Soy is destroying the Amazon; therefore, vegans are destroying the Amazon". I first heard it two decades ago when I already knew it was false, and a friend just told me her daughter said it to her recently. Firstly, vegans are a small (but beautiful) percentage of the human population, so while they may eat more soy than average, we would have to be eating 50 times more soy than the rest of the population for the problems surrounding soy production to be laid at our feet. This, of course, isn't true, and tofu, tempeh, soy sauce, miso, and edamame are popular foods widely eaten around the world. Soy and soybean oil are also used in lots of foods that contain animal products, including prepackaged and processed foods. It's not all just eaten either, some 16% of soy globally is used in industrial processes, such as ethanol production, plastics, glues and so on, uses that everybody participates in. So vegans and vegetarians are only eating a tiny percentage of the soy eaten and used in the world. Before we blame the non-vegans for consuming soy, we must ask if they are the real reason so much soy is being grown in the Amazon. We may only think about the soy products in our supermarkets, but 75 - 80% of soy grown globally, including in the Amazon, is used to feed livestock. Again, though, we must ask if soy crops are the primary culprit behind the deforestation of one of the world's most complex and species-rich ecosystems. Again, we see that it is livestock, as 80% of land clearing in the Amazon basin is for beef cattle pasture.

The first time someone said "vegans are destroying the rainforests" to me, I thought this was going to be an easy enough thing to disabuse them of. I regaled them with some of these facts, but alas, it didn't seem to change anything. They certainly didn't say "Oh, I didn't know those facts, maybe I should eat fewer animal products". Instead, they walked off in a huff. It's almost as if they didn't really care about reducing their ethical or environmental footprint, but were just trying to argue against veganism.

What do barbed wire, cages, chains and other tools of confinement and oppression say about the lives of the animals who live there? What do they say about humanity? Some people have said we should call our current ecological age the Anthropocene, to acknowledge the overwhelming effect humans now have on the living systems of the world. This age began with our land clearing, burning, and the commercial exploitation of wild animals, but has gained pace since the Industrial Revolution. Humanity has selfishly used its ever-growing power to diminish the home we share with all other species. Livestock farming is one of the more obvious and exaggerated examples of this selfishness. Factory-farmed chickens, one of the most abused animals on Earth, are now over two-thirds of the mass of all birds. Humans and our livestock comprise over nine-tenths of the combined mass of all terrestrial species. Wild species are crowded into the remaining small portion, with most of them in the process of diminishing or disappearing. We often focus on human-caused extinction, but the massive loss of members of wild species has been even more catastrophic in terms of suffering. Since I was born, it is estimated that we have lost three-quarters of wildlife populations, with the number for large fish in the oceans being over nine-tenths.

There is no doubt humans are intelligent and have advanced organisational abilities, but on an evolutionary time scale, what have we used these traits for? To create a tyranny for all other life seems a petty, wasteful and terrible thing to do with our potential.

Transcending anthropocentrism

We have created ideas in order to justify our oppression. The religions and philosophies of societies invested in animal agriculture tend to centre around human supremacy, with only the gods of our imagination being higher than humans. In an example of how self-serving human thought can be, we imagined those gods to be obsessed with the lives of humans above all other things. The gods are incredibly concerned about the trivial details of human lives, but have little to say about all other life, except in how it relates to us. Our anthropocentrism flows out from our philosophies into the way we live, the things we consume and the technology we create. Our concrete and asphalt-dominated cities are deserts for wild animals, especially the animals that evolved in the places our cities have overrun.

Finding a path beyond anthropocentrism, a way to reintegrate human civilisation into the natural world, seems to be the only path forward for humanity that is not built on the oppression of everything else that lives. The positive emotions most people who spend time in nature feel tell us that if we allow nature to restore itself, we will be rewarded with happier and more beautiful lives as well. A new, more harmonious self and world await once we can shake off the habits and ideas of the past to find a more equitable relationship between humanity and the other life that co-evolved with us. The planet does not belong to us, we belong to it. All life has its own evolutionary paths that should not be subservient to human needs and desires, and indeed, we will, in the end, find out we flourish best together. Having the power to dominate other animals does not give us the moral right to do so. Rather, our treatment of other animals makes it evident that we need to spend more time on our collective philosophies. We must summon the collective maturity to responsibly wield our ever-increasing power.

What we do to animals, we in some way do to ourselves. Oppression not only damages the oppressed but also limits the flourishing of the oppressor. The livestock industry is oppression run rampant; it is a symptom of our myopia. The gradual replacement of these cruel, unnecessary industries will reflect a wider ethical and intellectual progression for us all. In the future, animal liberation will be something only to celebrate.

4. Bacon

Question

Mmmm bacon...

Alternatives

"I love steak" is almost as common. Other lines from the toxic masculinity script.

Summary

Saying "steak" or "bacon" to someone vegan is meanness in the guise of humour. We tend to think of humour and laughter as positive human expressions, but they are actually a complex part of communication. Laughter can be joyous and sincere, or fake and hollow. Sometimes people can't help but laugh, sometimes they force out a chuckle, and sometimes people engage in fake performative laughter. The latter sort of laughter can be part of status displays, or of declaring our identity with a person, group or mob. One shouldn't look for much emotional depth in people overly prone to fake laughter. Humour that relies on cruelty or meanness reveals the shallow character of both the instigator and those who laugh along. Such people are to be ignored or avoided, certainly not worried about too much, because being a shallow person is its own karma.

Discussion

There can be good jokes that make light of veganism, even some jokes that vegans will tell among themselves: "I decided to go vegan when I realised I had too many friends". Like any type of joke, these jokes can be clever, surprising, or interesting. Then, however, there are attempts at jokes that have few positive qualities, usually told by people who have few positive qualities. I've attended many protests against animal cruelty where people, almost always young men, will walk past and say, “I like bacon”, “I'm going to have a steak”, etc. They are statements that anyone who has done much animal activism will have heard repeatedly, beyond all tolerance for boredom. The people who say such things will repeat these phrases with the seeming pretence of having thought of them themselves. It is unlikely, however, that such people have added any original thoughts to our culture. Jokes, and just for convenience, we will call these boorish ejaculations jokes, don't get funnier with repetition, in the same way that repetition doesn't make lies become true, or stupid statements intelligent.

Let's also be clear about what is involved in making your average strip of bacon. We start with a breeding sow that has only ever lived confined in a concrete shed and surrounded by steel bars. Given the chance, pigs naturally build nests for their children, but this, along with fulfilling most other natural desires, will not be available to her. She will be artificially impregnated as soon as possible, something that will be repeated over her short life. After a gestation period between three and four months, she will give birth to a litter of piglets. Due to

the immense size of genetically bred pigs, the concrete floors they live on, and the confined nature of factory farms, sows crush their piglets at much higher rates than they would in the wild. This has led to the use of farrowing crates, which confine the mother, in many cases not allowing them to turn around. As soon as the piglets are weaned at three to four weeks, about a third of the time they would spend being weaned with their mother in the wild, her piglets will be taken, and she will be almost immediately impregnated again. The piglets will then have their tails, ears and teeth removed without anaesthetic. They will then be crammed into similar sheds that the mother they will never see again endured, with concrete floors and steel bars. The stress and boredom of this confinement will see common behaviours such as bar biting, attacking each other, and they will exhibit signs of chronic distress such as repetitive swaying, head bobbing and pacing back and forth. They will then be fed on a diet optimised to interact with their genetic breeding to bring them to market weight as soon as possible. After six months of this repetitive confinement, they will then be sent to slaughter. This short life is the product of intensive breeding that has doubled and tripled the rate at which pigs grow. Common methods of slaughtering pigs include suffocating them together in groups in gas chambers utilising carbon dioxide, or stunning them with an electrical current, hoisting them upside down, and "sticking" them with a sharp knife. It takes about 30 seconds of extreme stress for carbon dioxide to kill a pig. Studies have shown that up to a third of pigs are still conscious after electrical stunning, and are conscious while being hoisted and "stuck". This life of confinement and slaughter is experienced by one and a half billion pigs every year.

So that's what people participate in, and the more sadistic among them like to joke about.

Ugly humour

Human laughter is complicated, and science struggles to understand all the many reasons people laugh. Plenty of animals laugh as well, though seemingly for simpler expressions of joy or to communicate that they are playing. What is clear is that people often laugh at things not because they are spontaneously funny but for performative social reasons. This kind of laughter often sounds fake, like a jarring echo from a hollow, unkind place. Fake laughter often sounds like somebody read in a book about laughter and is trying to replicate it, but failing. You can recognise ugly laughter primarily by the way it seems forced out. It usually happens when someone is trying to assert their superiority, or put someone else down; what we call "laughing at" rather than "laughing with". Laughing at others' misfortunes is correlated with psychopathy and other destructive, including self-destructive, personality traits.

Many words have been spent arguing about what things it is OK to joke about. I personally enjoy a dash of schadenfreude. Humour, and perhaps especially dark humour, can make light of dark times and places. It can help us deal with painful or uncomfortable things without having them overwhelm us. The rich, deep humour of some Holocaust survivors is evidence of this. Sometimes it is life-affirming to laugh when the alternative is to cry, or to laugh when we don’t want to or think we should. We can take all of the world’s ugliness and misfortune and find something to smile about in it. However, jokes that reinforce or give space to existing evils in the world, jokes that have victims, must be held to a higher standard.

Humour, or the pretence of it, isn't inherently moral or immoral. In addition to easing our load, humour can be used to bolster oppression and cruelty. A smile can be a leer, a smirk or a sneer; it can be a mask hiding the mob's ugly face. Humour can be used by the angry, irrational part of us to drown out the quiet voice of the intellect, of introspection, empathy and subtle thoughts. Sartre famously said, "Hell is other people", but hell is only some other

people, and a sign of this sort of person is how much of their humour is jeering and ill-intended. Witness how the laughing emoji on social media started out as a positive expression, but has since been used and abused by conspiracy theorists and trolls who need to mock people kinder and more mature than themselves.

Humour and empathy

Psychologically, there is something called a cold joke. It's been witnessed in atrocities towards humans for centuries. Perpetrators of immoral acts, killings, torture and the like, use the pretence of humour to avoid the psychological ramifications of something disturbing they are participating in. They bond using jeers and fake laughter with other damaged souls, exhibiting the same insincerity and toxic emotion that probably defines most of the relationships in their lives. If someone can laugh about atrocities, such as billions of innocent animals suffering in factory farms and slaughterhouses, and if they see a person caring about this suffering as weak or pathetic, we might ponder how capable they are of true, empathetic connection with another sentient being. Would such a person be able to love anyone else fully and selflessly in their lives? We might even pity the shallowness they wear so proudly, because emotional connection, the ability to empathise and care for others, to be able to be vulnerable and trust others at a deep level, is among the things that most give life beauty and meaning.

Pigs, sheep, goats, chickens, cows: We should recognise something of ourselves when we look into the face of another sentient creature. These are thinking and feeling beings we share our evolutionary kinship with, who seek to be happy as we do, and we can witness that when our eyes connect. Each animal in a factory farm or slaughterhouse is a thinking, feeling individual that matters. We can forget that on the inconceivable scale of animal agriculture. More animals suffer and die in our industrial prison systems every week than humans killed in all wars during our entire bloody history. We look away from this reality, and perhaps that helps us keep its existence from our daily awareness. In modern times, we have outsourced our killing to others, usually poor and disadvantaged slaughterhouse workers. We have pushed the sight, sound and stench of killing to the outskirts of cities. For most of history, people lived closely with wild animals and felt a kinship with them. They knew that the animals around them had family and relationships of their own, that they were intelligent, and worthy of respect. They would call other animals brothers and sisters, other species fellow nations. Even when they needed to kill an animal to survive, they would often apologise to them and thank them for their sacrifice. That respect has been replaced by the morality of out of sight, out of mind. We now mock the animals we rely upon by using their names as insults. What have we become?

Wanting to believe

The blood of this terrible industry stains the hands of all who participate in it. We can start repairing our relationship with the non-human world by at least showing higher levels of respect for the lived experience of farmed animals. The beings we force to live in lightless sheds, in cages, taken from their families, whom we line up for their turn in slaughterhouses, are not simply a product of mass consumption. They are each a unique somebody, with their own personality, relationships, desires and purposes. These lives and deaths over which we wield a god-like power can, according to our choices and whims, be either more terrible or bearable, more beautiful or ugly, confined or free. Motherhood, love, friendship, society, we take from them so much, and part of the reason we so easily rob other creatures of these experiences is that many anthropocentrically think of high emotions as uniquely human. All

animals evolved from a single ancestor, but mammals are our especially close evolutionary kin. Much of how they interact and process the world is similar to our own experience. We know this when we interact or play with them. We selectively, however, choose to forget this when we associate them with our food. Studies have been done that ask people about the internal lives of animals. Study participants will tend to rate animal sentience much lower if they are eating an animal product at the time, and higher if they are eating a plant-derived snack. How much animal suffering has occurred because of our subconscious need to deny their ability to suffer?

If humans actually needed to eat animals, if there were nothing else we could survive and thrive on, then ethics would still demand a radical overhaul of our farming system. However, we are omnivores who can eat a wide variety of foods; therefore, eating animals is a choice we can make and unmake. The world will be a better place when animals are no longer the intended victims of our food system. The alternative to a plant-based diet is playing a greater part in oppression. We might even have to join the cold jokers and try to feel better about our involvement in killing animals by saying cruel and offensive things, and pretending that our boorishness and sadism are humorous. Or we could take a more heroic stance.

A kinder path

Hopefully, one day, keeping animals in factory farms, and maybe even killing them, will be illegal. Currently, though, people have the choice to do so and pay for others to do so. To choose to treat other beings as purely a means to our ends, whether for food, entertainment, clothing or other consumer goods, is a barren, life-diminishing choice; a choice many people aren't even making entirely consciously. The less ethical and open-minded people are, the more tightly they will cling to their existing habits and try to hamper anyone on a nobler path ahead of them. Indeed, many people seem to be obsessed with ethical status, and especially the idea that anyone tries to do better by following a more compassionate diet. It is sad to see people trapped in prisons of habitual mediocrity, so unable to imagine a different self that they fear escape from their self-imposed walls. It is a poor use of the possibilities of life, peering out suspiciously at the world, at difference, fearing change and growth, despising anybody who reminds us by word or example that there are kinder and better ways we can live. The simple truth is that when people are mocking others, they feel better because at least they aren't thinking about their own flaws, limitations and failed dreams. There is, however, a better way, one that leads to our greater individual and collective flourishing. In a world full of expansive, beautiful possibilities for our relationship with other life, why wouldn't we want to spend our time pursuing a kinder path? Many great deeds need to be done to heal the world, things that can challenge us to embody our highest selves. The animals and the world need us to be heroes.

The greatest potential a person can try to fulfil is their ethical potential. With respect to animals, most of us have room for improvement. While we confront the darkness and suffering all too present in life, even confronting our own limitations, humour can be a balm that helps keep us motivated and sane. Laughter is a mysterious gift, and life is too short and precious to squander our time with fakeness and meanness. Let us all laugh less often at others, and more often at ourselves and our shared predicament.

Finally, a joke I hope carnists can appreciate: How many meat eaters does it take to change a lightbulb? None, they prefer to stay in the dark.

5. Hitler

Question

Wasn't Hitler a vegetarian?

Alternatives

Sometimes it is Pol Pot, Mussolini, Charles Manson, or whoever was a terrible human being.

Summary

Hitler was one of the worst people in history, but associating him with all vegetarians is a stretch, just as it is to associate him with all Germans, people with bad moustaches, or dog lovers. We should be more informed and respectful about historical atrocities than to use their victim's suffering for our own ideological purposes. The phrase for this is "false moral equivalence". It is not only illogical but perversely ironic to try to morally equate those who perpetrated the mass killing of one species with those trying to stop the mass killing of other species. Studies show that people who care about animal rights are more likely, not less, than the rest of the population to be concerned with human rights. It is no shock that it is a general apathy rather than a specific compassion for animals that we must struggle against. Veganism is about compassion and encompasses all animals, even humans.

Discussion

Godwin’s law arose in the early days of Internet discussion. It states that as a discussion or debate goes on, the probability of someone making a comparison involving the Nazis approaches certainty. The original law also said the person who first makes such a comparison is said to lose the debate. So it was inevitable that people would try to equate those who want to be kinder to animals with some of history’s worst monsters. Vegans and vegetarians are seen as choosing to care about animals, and people decide, with zero evidence, that this must not include people. Misanthropes may be slightly overrepresented in the vegan and vegetarian community compared to the rest of society, but they are a minority. Surveys repeatedly show that caring about humans and non-humans is not a dichotomy. Caring about both is a mutually reinforcing expression of deeper compassion.

We should tread extremely carefully in making comparisons between aspects of one historical injustice and another. This is especially true if we don't have a deep understanding of or personal relationship with the injustices we are comparing. Whilst there may be some important ways in which atrocities can be similar, as they involve illegitimate force and inflicting pain, there are always fundamental ways in which they are different and defy easy comparison. If we want to communicate with others, we need to understand their different experiences and worldviews. Even discussing the treatment of animals and humans in the same conversation can be triggering or controversial to people who have a speciesist and

anthropocentric mindset. We might think the comparisons we make between human and non-human injustice help them to understand our point, but might actually be creating an unnecessary barrier to them hearing what we say at all. So, we must try to tread carefully in discussing this issue, as I will try to here as well.

Hitler, Pol Pot, and Mussolini all said a lot of things, far too many things, but none ever said they were vegan. While in his last years, Hitler claimed to be a vegetarian, the evidence is fairly shaky that this was true, as we shall see. Despite this, people repeatedly try to make these claims to denigrate the idea of compassion towards animals, so such myths are something we need to address. We can start by acknowledging that evil people have eaten vegetables, maybe even a lot of vegetables. It is also statistically certain that there will be evil and terrible people over the last few thousand years who have followed a vegetarian or mostly vegetarian diet. The questions we have before us, however, are whether a plant-based diet or philosophy either caused those people to be evil or made them more evil. Perhaps we can discover a scale on which we can equate a person's level of evil with the proportion of vegetables in their diet. At the outset, this seems highly implausible, and indeed we might expect the opposite to be true.

Dietary choices and moral complexity

Tolstoy said vegetarianism was proof that a person's pursuit of moral perfection is sincere. In our modern world of factory farming, this probably needs an update to include “veganism”, but while it sounds nice, not everyone gives up eating meat for the pursuit of ethics. Health, religion, spirituality, culture, digestive issues, allergies and trying to impress an attractive vegetarian or vegan are all common reasons for abstaining from animal products that have nothing to do with ethics. If a person abstains from eating animal products for reasons other than ethics, it probably doesn’t tell us too much about their ethics.

People have often claimed that eating meat changes our nature, saying that the violence we do to animals ferments in our soul, or even that the violence pervades their flesh and inhabits us when we consume it. Stopping eating meat would definitely make us less violent, but mainly because we would stop the violence done during its production. It may be possible that there are hormonal or other chemical transfers going on when we consume animal flesh that might make us more prone to violence, but we'd need better evidence for this. It’s also possible for the opposite to be true, that meat makes us more passive; some of the animals we consume have gentle natures, which is part of the reason they make good targets for oppression, and perhaps we become more docile like them as we consume their hormones and so on. For now, though, we don’t seem to be able to confidently assign good or bad behaviour to what people eat. People are complex, and most of us are ethical in some areas but have moral blind spots in others, so what parts should we blame on their diet? We need to know more about someone to say if they are overall a good person than what they had for dinner. Families in India have abstained from meat for many centuries, but it's doubtful that every single person they produced was some sort of saintly figure. Vegetarians and vegans are flawed, trying to figure out this life and making mistakes as they go along, just like everybody else.

A traitor to humanity

Now, let's add to the millions of words humanity has wasted talking about the wretched and pathetic Adolf Hitler. Hitler definitely ate meat regularly until he was almost 50, by which time he had taken over Germany and was having his political enemies put to death, followed by

Jews, Roma, homosexuals, Seventh Day Adventists, and people with disabilities. Mass killings of non-Aryans started after the invasion of the USSR in 1941. Yet it was 1942, 21 years after Hitler became head of the National Socialists, well into the war and almost 10 years after the first concentration camps were opened, before he ever seemed to say anything remotely vegetarian. So the claim is immediately on shaky ground. If we think his diet was in any way related to his crimes, it is not his late vegetarianism we might look at, but rather his 50 years of meat eating before it.

So why did Hitler experiment with vegetarianism? Hitler had long-term stomach problems, and some say doctors advised him to eat a mostly vegetable diet around 1937, though Herman Hess said Hitler always made exceptions for his favourites like liver dumplings. It seems eating less meat was a common prescription for stomach problems at the time, as it was also given to Mussolini. Even later on, people, apparently unafraid of the consequences of crossing Hitler, snuck meat into his food, and if Hitler noticed, he would complain about it hurting his stomach. Hitler's primary chef claimed she used animal broth in cooking for him, and his dietitian also claims to have snuck bone marrow into his food. So, how much Hitler was ever really vegetarian is hard to tell from these anecdotes. It's also worth noting that the Nazis banned existing vegetarian societies in 1935 and forced them to merge into Nazi-controlled health organisations. Hitler did show some concern for animals, liked dogs, and the Nazis did enact laws against animal cruelty. Of course, if people were just pure evil, history would be a lot simpler, and the Germans would have figured out he wasn't a worthy leader much sooner. The Nazis also had social programmes and helped the poor, so although the Nazis as a collective were incomprehensibly vile, not every single thing they did was. As they say, even a stopped clock can be right twice a day. Hitler may have been mostly vegetarian for a few of his final years, but what can we draw from that?

Pol Pot and the meaning of words

Pol Pot led an insane and murderous regime in Cambodia. The problem for people claiming that Pol Pot was a vegetarian or even a vegan is that this is relatively recent history. The people who cooked for Pol Pot are still alive, and we can ask them about it. People have and they have told us that he ate all sorts of things, fish, cobra, boar, etc. While he was forcing much of the population of Cambodia to starve, Pol Pot and the members of his regime were eating well, consuming their meat with imported wines. An official who knew him seemed to say he was a vegetarian, but who knows what they were basing that on? Certainly, I can't find anywhere that Pol Pot made the claim about himself.

We must understand that many people get confused about what the word vegetarian means, and this was even more true in the past. A relevant passage talking about Hitler’s diet from the New York Times in 1937 says, “It is well known that Hitler is a vegetarian”, which the article then follows with “he occasionally relishes a slice of ham and relieves the tediousness of his diet with such delicacies as caviar”. Studies show that even today, many people, especially older people, get confused when asked to define vegan or vegetarian. They regularly think it is just excluding red meat, or not eating much meat, or eating chicken or fish. Diet surveys have had to be amended because of the poor understanding of the terms vegetarian and vegan. Now, after a survey asks people if they are vegetarian or vegan, they will often then ask, "When was the last time you ate chicken/fish?" etc. This is necessary because of the confusion about what people ascribe to the word. If people today use terms like vegetarian and vegan loosely and incorrectly, when plant-based diets are much more present in the culture, we shouldn't expect people decades ago to be clearer about them. What did someone in 1940s

Germany mean when they said vegetarian, or in 1970s Cambodia? Pol Pot doesn’t seem to have been vegan or vegetarian, so you can't tarnish us with him. Instead, he seems to be another moral blight on the carnists of the world.

One for the haters

Finally, Charles Manson. A lot of slightly unhinged websites gleefully assert he was a vegetarian and a couple of better-hinged ones as well, though none of them provides much evidence, so I had to search for it myself. Manson certainly wasn't a vegetarian when he was younger, and his first stint in prison has no records of him requesting non-standard prison meals. Once he left prison to find the flower power generation in full steam, that's when he started changing his look and diet. From Manson's statements after this time, he says things about killing animals, but they seem as much to point out the hypocrisy of society and its attitudes towards killing as to tell people not to eat meat. Charles "Tex" Watson, in his autobiographical account of his time in The Manson Family, wrote that Manson's vegetarian rhetoric was often selectively applied. Though the group preferred to scavenge vegetarian food, they would accept animal products. Watson also described the Family butchering animals at their Spahn Ranch, and it was said that Manson would frequently visit a hot dog and burger bar. After this, though, the evidence for Manson's vegetarianism becomes clearer. In Manson's murder trial, he asserted, "I don’t even like to eat meat - that is how much I am against killing". Apparently, at least Charles Manson believes that vegetarianism leads to the opposite of murderousness. Manson started requesting vegetarian meals in his later, longer stint in prison, and his cellmates also agree that he consistently ate vegetarian meals. So it is clear that Manson was a vegetarian for most of his later life. We will chalk this one up as a "win" for the naysayers, though again, with the caveat that Manson wasn't a vegetarian until his early to mid-30s. Of course, there was a wave of vegetarianism amongst the hippie culture in 1960s California, but as much as conservatives feared it at the time, there wasn't a wave of Manson Family-style psychopathy.

Linking diet and personality

If anyone wanted serious answers as to whether violent people were more likely to eat or not eat meat, it would seem a reasonably simple area to study. Get prison meal records and see which diet correlated with the most violent offenders. One suspects that if people in the legal and justice system noticed an outsized number of cases linking vegetarianism or veganism to murderousness, someone would have already done this relatively simple study. What has been studied is whether a healthy diet helps people reduce their violent tendencies, and the result is pretty conclusive that it does, so maybe people who are worried about high levels of violence should advocate for healthy eating over stirring up a culture war.

What motivates the repetition of this claim about Hitler et al to people who don't eat meat? There is evidence that some people seem to want to pre-emptively attack people who take a strong ethical stance because they imagine the other person will judge or shame them. It is like there is a defensive conversation already going on in their mind that someone taking an ethical stance unknowingly steps into. People don’t want to be looked down upon; they deeply want status, including moral status, and will do substantial intellectual callisthenics to claim it. Surveys show that many meat eaters are uncomfortable about the treatment of animals in the food system, but they are stuck in the habit of how they eat and don’t want to change. This leaves them in an uncomfortable mental state, which psychology calls cognitive dissonance. To continue eating animal products without it overly troubling their conscience, they need to try

to find strong intellectual justifications for their behaviours. What could be stronger than associating vegans and vegetarians with history's worst monsters like the Nazis? We can imagine a simple subconscious internal dialogue, "It seems more ethical to be vegetarian. I am not a vegetarian and do not wish to become so. To maintain my ethical status, I must undermine vegetarianism". So you get "Hitler was bad. Hitler was a vegetarian. All vegetarians are bad", but more importantly, what follows: "I am not a vegetarian, therefore I am good". Aristotle wouldn't have thought much of this syllogism, but even poor logic will be looked upon favourably by a person desiring an exit from a moral quandary. Judging others negatively is a primary way that people redirect their negative inner voice away from themselves.

Adding to poor logic, we also have poor statistics. You can't make widespread inferences about a group of people from cherry-picked examples. Even if Hitler and Pol Pot actually were ethical vegetarians, what about Mao Tse Tung, Joseph Stalin, Talat Pasha, Suharto, Saddam Hussein, Atilla the Hun, Genghis Khan, Nero, Caligula, King Leopold, Idi Amin, and also the rest of the Nazis? The Nazis may have looked up to Hitler, but very few of them were tempted to follow his diet. But you don’t find vegans saying to carnists, “Oh, you eat meat, well, did you know that most of history's greatest monsters were avid meat eaters?” Although it may be true, it doesn’t tell us much about the character of the meat eater we are talking to. It's actually hard to say whether a vegan diet makes someone anything, because most vegans didn’t start life as vegans; they too ate meat, not because they were bad people, but because they unquestioningly conformed to what they were taught while being raised. Vegans should be able to understand what it is like to be someone who hadn’t really considered the lives of other animals enough, or didn’t have the tools and mindset to do something about it, because they were once there themselves.

Universal compassion

Given the scale of animal suffering at human hands, the billions huddled in factory farms, their bodies altered to be production machines, and the many wild species of the world in retreat or facing extinction, it seems impossible to argue against the fact that the way humans treat animals is a moral blind spot on which some light is urgently needed. People judging those who argue for kinder treatment of animals should think carefully before engaging in knee-jerk reactions against them. Even if you think vegans are wrong, is having compassion, maybe even too much compassion for other species, something more terrible than the problem animal advocates are trying to bring attention to? This is not to say that unempathetic vegans should get a free pass to be rude or inconsiderate. Veganism, when properly understood, is about compassion and consideration for all that can suffer, and this should include humans. Vegans would be advised to try to consistently embody the compassion inherent in their message in the way they present it.

Finally, I will speak for veganism, because that is what I am, and I have no place to speak for vegetarianism. The intellectual and ethical progress of humanity has always been improved by widening our circles of compassion. Any outlook that considers humans but not animals, or animals but not humans, or some subset of humans or animals, is incomplete. All sentient beings deserve consideration of their interests, at the very least, in concordance with their level of sentience. An ethically and intellectually consistent life has at its core compassion for all beings who can suffer, for all earthlings thrown into these evolutionary moments of existence together. Veganism is not purely a diet; it spans far beyond that into a philosophy of universal compassion. Anyone advocating violence towards sentient beings, or even degrading the value of their lives, cannot be a vegan.

6. Plants

Question

Don't plants have feelings?

Alternatives

Carrots scream when you cut them. Eating plants kills more animals than just eating animals.

Summary

Our moral responsibility towards a sentient being should be proportionate to their ability to suffer. While the science on plant sentience is evolving and often surprising, it does not yet ascribe to plants the high levels of sentience we find in vertebrates and closely related invertebrates. What science has known for over a century, if it wasn't already obvious intuitively, is that cows, sheep, ducks, pigs, chickens, horses, dogs, and many of the other animals people eat have complex senses, emotions, and internal worlds. If we want to cause less suffering in the world, the simplest change we can make is to stop paying for industrial animal agriculture and slaughter. Also, and somewhat obviously, farm animals are fed tremendous amounts of plant material. So, if people are seriously concerned about plants, again, the simplest thing they can do is eliminate or reduce their consumption of animal products.

Discussion

Plants are pretty amazing. They appear to have their own versions of many of the senses humans experience, including touch, smell, taste, sight and sound. This makes sense as humans and plants evolved from a common ancestor over a billion years ago. We still share something like 50% of our DNA with trees and bananas. Delving into the science of plant sentience is fascinating and challenging. People who pose questions like “Don't plants have feelings?” to vegans, however, are unlikely to be interested in the science for its own sake, much less will they be seeking the next level of compassionate consideration in their lives. Paradoxically, they are less likely to care about plants, forests and ecosystems than the average person. What these people are actually seeking is an intellectual sideshow that helps avoid the more morally urgent question: Is the vast amount of unnecessary suffering we cause in animal agriculture morally acceptable?

Status and ethics

Why do some people grab at such flimsy pretexts in conversations around a topic as important and consequential as animal suffering? Part of this is a lack of moral seriousness or having dark triad personality traits, but perhaps the greater part has to do with status. As a part of our evolution as communal social beings, we can be incredibly attuned to our place in the

social hierarchy. People seek social status of almost any kind; it doesn't really matter what the status pyramid is constructed of, so long as they are near the top of it. Part of this is ethical status, which some people seek even though they aren't too concerned about living ethically. Ethical status is just another of the myriad facets of comparison that can be incorporated within the statement "They think they are better than me". There are broadly two strategies we can use to enhance our ethical status: one is to live a more considered, compassionate and selfless life; the other is to continue living as we already do and use our intellectual resources to better justify ourselves. The question about whether plants have feelings is part of the latter strategy.

Ethical status feels very inconvenient for people who have spent their lives being habituated to unethical behaviours. White people raised in the segregated American South virtually rioted when a 6-year-old African-American girl, Ruby Ridges, was enrolled in an all-white school. After a relatively short time, people calmed down, and integration in those same schools became commonplace and unremarkable. We have been raised in a consumerist, wasteful culture, one in which we are largely defined by how we acquire and spend money. We have been taught to judge the "good life" in material rather than ethical terms. Most people have not been raised to ask about what goes on in the world before products are brought to us, or what happens once we are done with them. The profits of the global market are highly dependent on sweatshops, forced labour, inequality, factory farms, slaughterhouses, political manipulation, global conflict, and countless forms of environmental destruction and pollution. To become ethically conscious of such things forces the realisation that, if we are even to begin to minimise our contribution to the negative aspects of our consumerism, we must put more care into our lifestyle and choices, especially our consumption choices. The system and society we are in, however, do not encourage or reward such care, and they certainly don't always make it easy. Billions of dollars are spent every year on marketing and normalising profligate consumerism to us, lobbying and funding political leaders to keep the system going. Trying to live more ethically can even feel like we are constantly pushing against the flow of the consumerist culture we are embedded within.

Why should we take on this ethical burden? Why not just go with the flow? There are few compelling social or economic reasons to rail against the global beast of consumerism. A much easier path is conformity to it, to continue to follow whatever way of consuming and eating our upbringing happened to churn out. There is, however, the minor, nagging problem of this way of living being inconsistent with an ethical, considered and compassionate life. The human mind, in all of its subtlety and creativity, can help us avoid this nagging problem if we want or allow it to. Self-interest and ego can play a powerful, warping role in our logic and ethics. Our minds can find plausible justifications and loopholes for almost anything we want, certainly plausible enough for our minds that are prone to confirmation bias. So people will argue without much thought to an ethical life that, by an uncanny coincidence, they are already living the most practically ethical life. The opposite of what such people would like is to live what Socrates called the examined life. Introspection, after all, raises the possibility of casting a critical eye over one's own beliefs or behaviour. The status many desire is not achieved by raising uncomfortable questions about themselves, questions they fear the answers to because they might require significant change. So they create intellectual barriers to ethical questions. To ask if plants have feelings creates a smoke screen that helps divert an uncomfortable conversation about our personal contribution to suffering.

Scientific studies have often shown this sort of character displacement, sometimes called do-gooder derogation. As part of this common human trait, when someone else acts ethically in

their own lives, it forces us into potentially uncomfortable ethical introspection, and we instinctively don't like them for it. We might then try to shift the conversation to any foolishness, duplicity and immorality of the other person that we feel is "showing us up", even though this is unlikely to be their intention. As those fond of gossip have always, at least subconsciously, known, conversations pointing out other people's ethical or intellectual shortcomings feel much better than sincerely pondering or acknowledging your own.

What about plants? What are your shoes made of? What about people? What about bacteria? What about a fairytale farm where the animals have great lives? Such questions are fairly transparent displacements from much more important and obvious questions about our reality and the consequences of our choices in it. This is at least partly understandable. We all fear judgment and self-judgment. We fear self-doubt, painful thoughts, being uncertain about our choices in life, and changes we don't understand fully. Ultimately, though, if we wish to live more ethically, we must confront some personal discomfort and be willing to imagine and create a different self.

Sophistry and truth

Using edge cases to brush away the immense scale of suffering in animal agriculture is a misuse of our intellectual potential. The ancient Greek philosophers had a word for bad-faith intellectualising: “sophistry”. It described the engagement with important and serious questions at a trite and superficial level. A Sophist's main priority is to win the argument, not to uncover flaws in their own logic, to grow through mutual discourse, or to search for deeper truths. When confronted with humanity’s often brutal treatment of billions of animals, responding with questions like “What about plants?” is usually a Sophist tactic. No one of any moral seriousness could wave away the unnecessary suffering of billions of highly sentient beings with a trite comment or a clever quip.

Suspiciously, many people’s political and ethical opinions align with what they want to do, what they have always done and what they perceive to be in their self-interest. This tendency to bend reason to the shape of our habits and desires is called motivated reasoning. It is a deep cognitive bias we all share, one that shapes reason around our desires as surely as gravity bends light around a celestial body. None of us is above this bias, and it can only be partially mitigated by sustained effort. The way the religious zealot thinks is a clear example of this. For them, truth starts not in doubt, in epistemology or philosophy, but rather it emerges from the starting point of their religious texts and beliefs. Whatever fact or piece of knowledge about the world they encounter must be reconciled with their religious beliefs or else denied as a threat to those beliefs. This logical bias has made people seriously claim the Earth is only a few thousand years old, or that animals were designed by an invisible being. No one would reach these positions starting from first principles; instead, you must have a religious worldview implanted in you before you can accept them. This logical bias is not confined to religion, many people place their faith in their existing habits and prejudices, the way they were raised and so on. It is a form of personal and philosophical hubris, but we must understand that it is rarely deliberate or intended as such. It is problematic though. People raised with an anthropocentric, carnist worldview, will have find that this obscures something that should be obvious: the way we treat animals is one of history's great moral failures.

Pushback

It's not just that people raised with a carnist worldview will find it hard to imagine themselves

eating fewer animal products, but they will often object to anyone even raising the idea. Add to this the entrenched economic, cultural and political interests in animal agriculture, and we see there is a huge amount of inertia we must overcome in making a kinder world.

In changing society, even to make it better, we must expect pushback from the status quo. We can expect resistance from individuals even if for no other reason that people are often lazy, fear new things, and don't like change. Every time humans have tried to evolve beyond some ethical horror, those most powerfully agitating for the change have faced resistance, including violence. Opposition has come not just from elites profiting from the status quo but also from large sections of the population, often seemingly invested in little more than habit and conformity. The wider social narrative around social change, pushed by politics, the media and many people, has often been that the current levels of injustice were not only tolerable, but ethically superior to alternatives; that the real problem was the people trying to foment change and upset the order of things. In our current societies, living ethically is unfortunately rarely as simple as lazy conformity. Instead, the interwoven complexity of our societies requires an ethical journey of constant re-evaluation, most importantly of our shared cultural frames of reference. Moral character requires us to follow the truth wherever it leads, to defy social norms where necessary, and sometimes requires us to raise a lonely defiant fist in the face of an irrational mob. Living ethically requires embarking on an open, honest and introspective dialogue that fearlessly seeks out our moral oversights and failings. This is especially true in relation to freeing ourselves from the corruptions of our own power. Above all, moral character requires the strength to look unblinking into the ethical mirror.

There is an often cruel world that farm animals inhabit beyond our sight that we are part of creating, and therefore, we must bear our part of the moral responsibility for. Justifying the suffering and slaughter of sentient beings for luxury food items must be held to an exceptionally high ethical and philosophical bar. Using our intelligence to displace our uneasiness about the treatment of animals is a sign that we fear a true reckoning with ourselves; that we fear questioning our part in the sentient lives we affect, lives that have unjustly had power and agency taken from them. In our current culture of distraction and mindless consumerism, the heroic stance is to fearlessly question our own integrity.

Moral seriousness

Many questions vegans are asked stem from a lack of moral seriousness. People will seem to argue about things vigorously, but ultimately, they aren't ethically invested in the conversation. They see an argument about eating animals as little different to an argument about which is the best sports team, or which place has the best pizza. Let us, however, give these people's level of moral seriousness the benefit of the doubt. We've moved a long way away from plants, so let's return and answer their question seriously.

Does eating a plant-based diet cause more suffering? The land-based animals that humans most often eat are herbivores, fed from the same farming system that we use to feed humans. Around a third of the grain we grow globally, and a higher percentage of grain in many countries such as my own, is used to feed livestock. Animals, especially larger animals, are inefficient converters of plant foods into edible human protein. The vast majority of soybeans, for instance, grown globally are fed to livestock. For a bovine to produce 1kg of meat, it needs to be fed 25 kg of soybeans. If these soybeans were eaten directly by humans, we would remove all of the inefficiency and environmental concerns of feeding them through the intestines of an animal. Eating animals fed on plants requires many more plants to be used to

feed us than if we just ate plants. Paradoxically, maybe, when humans eat only plants, fewer plants are eaten.

Related to this are the animals are killed during the harvesting of grain and other farming practices. When someone eats an animal product, they don't sidestep these deaths, but increase them. Because so much grain is fed to farm animals, a vegan diet kills fewer of these collateral-damage animals. Again, this is because eating plant foods avoids the waste of inefficiently cycling nutrients through other animals.

So we've treated these questions seriously, but It is revealing that carnists only begin caring about plants or the animals killed as a byproduct of their food system when they think it might be a useful tool with which to intellectually beat other people. Vegans actually do care about these animals, for their own sake. It is probably only a farming system underpinned by the ethics that vegans espouse that will start to look more seriously at how to minimise these unfortunate deaths. Vegans must, unfortunately, exist in a non-vegan world, with non-vegan farming practices. Especially in our current world, a vegan diet cannot be perfect, cannot be entirely without animal death, but it can and does involve far fewer deaths. Every vegan life is another vote for a better world; however, for a more compassionate outlook on the ramifications of our farming system.

Weighing sentience

Again, to take the question about plants more seriously than it is asked, just like all life on this planet, plants have their own evolutionary journey that deserves respect. It is an interesting and evolving question of what our duty is to these beings we share our very distant evolutionary origins with. Plants don't have a central nervous system because it's not evolutionarily useful to waste energy creating receptors for pain that you can't do very much about. They do react to stimuli in their environment, even resisting attack, but this is done via a biochemical system different to animals. Plant biology is many and varied, and there is a lot more nuance than I can cover here or even know. There aren't even really distinct, easily identifiable separate kingdoms of plants and animals. In the web of evolution, the distinction between species is often subtle and very much part of a continuum of different evolutionary strategies, a web of interrelated life stretching out over time and space. Amid this complexity and given the power of human agency, we need to continually question what our ethical duties are and on what basis we make our judgments.

Some people take animal suffering as seriously as any vegan, but they think it is ethically justifiable to eat very simple creatures, bivalves like oysters and mussels, or to eat insect products like honey. Vegans may not agree with this, but we generally have greater respect for people who have thought through things and followed through with ethically motivated changes than those who blindly conform to whatever ideas they grew up with. History teaches us that questioning the received wisdom we were raised with is often a requisite precursor to ethical progress. For many societies in human history, cannibalism, human sacrifice, slavery, class, caste and many other things we now think are unethical were cultural norms.

Darwin and most eminent biologists since him have understood that the common evolutionary heritage we share with other creatures expresses itself through us. This includes the fact that we share the core of our sentience with other beings. Humans are not a wholly different kind of being; instead, we are similar beings with some differences and additions. Most of our conscious awareness is actually probably quite similar, concerned as it is with the

requirements of our body, perceiving the world and so on. We do not experience existence completely differently from them and thus do not exist in a separate moral universe. What overlap there is may always be up for debate and questioning, but not that there is significant overlap, certainly far more than we have hitherto acknowledged with our magical and religious ideas of ourselves. Many vegans follow a philosophy called sentientism, which holds that sentience is the important thing that we should consider in our treatment of others, and most importantly, what Jeremy Bentham called "their ability to suffer". This is opposed to the dominant paradigm of speciesism, a way of looking at non-human life as of lesser worth, not because of any rationally justified innate capabilities or sensations, but purely because they are not human. Other aspects of speciesism include the question of why animals on factory farms are treated so inhumanely when they are just as sentient and able to suffer as the cats and dogs that people often lavish affection on and generally consider members of their family. If someone agrees it is cruel not to walk a dog regularly, but then unquestioningly eats an intelligent pig whose life has been one of confinement in the factory farm, to then face the slaughterhouse, then the person clearly lacks ethical consistency and is guilty of speciesism.

Duty of care

Other life exists with us, not for us. Humanity is failing in the duty of care our higher sentience and power give us over other beings on this planet. All life has its own story and place in evolution that should not be considered automatically subservient to human desire. As our science and understanding of sentience evolve, we will have to re-evaluate our positions to most ethically sustain ourselves. Right now, however, a deep, obvious and uncontroversial question is staring back at us from behind barbed wire and metal bars, from within cages and fishing nets, from the confines of the factory farm and the slaughterhouse. They wait huddled, waiting for our answer, on which their entire experience of this life and world, and their very lives themselves depend. We know without question that these beings think and feel deeply, share many of our emotions and have similar senses of pleasure and pain. We know that if we ate fewer of these animals, it would bring a dramatic change to some individuals, and also that if we collectively ate fewer animals, it would be of major benefit to the flora and fauna on our planet. We can not let philosophical edge cases distract us from stating these obvious truths and improvements we could make in the face.

It is the lot of a finite mind in this infinite universe to have to think and act with incomplete knowledge and information. We will inevitably make mistakes, practically and ethically. It is not making mistakes we should fear, but the mindset that refuses to grow, to learn and then change when confronted with new thoughts and information. We can never have complete certainty about the intellectual and emotional lives of other beings, including other people. History teaches us, however, that when limited knowledge confronts expansive ethical questions, it is safest to err on the side of compassion.

7. Teeth

Question

What about our canine teeth?

Alternatives

Meat eating caused human brains to evolve. Our forward-looking eyes mean we are predators

Summary

The fact that we call two of our teeth “canine” is of little more scientific relevance than the fact that we have an Achilles heel or an Adam’s apple. Justifying killing should not be done lightly, and it should require an understanding of comparative biology more informed than we had thousands of years ago, when these teeth were named. The argument that our canine teeth mean we have to eat animals is a clear case of "believe me, not your own eyes". Look at the teeth of a carnivore, then of a herbivore, and then compare both to our teeth. Humans are opportunistic omnivores, with teeth more reminiscent of herbivores than obligate carnivores. Being omnivores means we can make choices about the makeup of our diet and whether it contributes to a kinder world.

Discussion

Science usually finds out those who profess things they would like to be true, but don't fully understand. The Ancient Greeks gave canine teeth their name. As awe-inspiring as the golden age of Greek philosophy was, it had some fundamental oversights in the way it approached things. The Greek philosopher Aristotle was the father of the biological sciences and one of history's greatest minds. In parts of Europe, he was so respected that for centuries they simply called him “the philosopher”. Still, he thought women had fewer teeth than men. We know he thought this because he considered it important enough to write it down so other people could learn from his knowledge. If he had taken the time to look in the mouths of more than a couple of women, he would have realised the error of his ways. It seems similar errors in thinking persist in our modern world with canine teeth.

Dog teeth

Spend a moment looking at the teeth of various carnivores and herbivores. Human teeth are so obviously more similar to herbivores that it is hard to understand anyone bringing this up as an argument for human meat-eating; if anything, it should lead to precisely the opposite conclusion. Still, there is that word canine, which apparently people can’t think very far beyond.

”Canine” is one name given to these teeth, but they are also called eye teeth because of where

they sit in our skull, or cuspids by the people who are paid to maintain them. You never hear anyone saying, "What about our cuspids?" Many animals that eat very different diets have canine teeth. We can include in this list antelopes, deer, camels, horses, boars, seals and walruses. Human canine teeth look rather inoffensive compared to those of some of our completely herbivorous relatives. Highland gorillas have fierce canines, but aside from the occasional insect, they live on plants.

Teeth can be used for many things; they are both tools and weapons. Canine teeth, more specifically, are used for dominance displays, fighting, gripping and tearing all kinds of foods. In some herbivorous species, only the males have large canine teeth, not because their diet is different from that of females, but because they use them to fight and show dominance. Even the dogs that live with humans after whom canine teeth are named are no longer carnivores. Dogs have lived with us for so long that they, too, have become omnivorous. Some studies even show that domesticated dogs live longer lives if fed a plant-based diet. Unlike our teeth, though, the teeth of domestic dogs clearly show their recent meat-eating origins. Dogs can still kill relatively large animals using their teeth, something humans would find almost impossible. Can you imagine a human trying to hack away at a buffalo's neck with their teeth and getting very far?

That human teeth resemble herbivorous teeth might tell us something about the role of meat in our evolutionary diet. Like our closest evolutionary relatives, we lived primarily on plants. There is incredible variation in the diets of humans who lived in often extreme environments, but anywhere that edible plants were plentiful, the human diet mostly consisted of them. Some of our closest relatives, such as chimpanzees, whose teeth are remarkably similar to human teeth, also eat some meat, but it is an incidental part of their diet. In the most meat-heavy chimpanzee troops, animals might make up 5-10% of their calories, but the percentage for most troops is much less. Our teeth and much of our biology tell us that humans, also with some regional variation, were similar.

Our now extinct but even closer relatives, the Neanderthals, had larger canine teeth than modern humans. Neanderthals ate much more meat as a percentage of their diet than we Homo Sapiens did, perhaps up to 80% in some regions. Scientists conjecture that our ability to thrive on a much wider array of foods was one of the things that may have contributed to us outcompeting and then entirely replacing the Neanderthals.

If we are comparing the anatomy of canines and humans, we can see that dogs also have claws, something that all land-based carnivores have. Look at the human hand with our short, soft nails. Our hands are perfectly designed for doing the sort of things tree-dwelling animals do, like swinging from trees and picking fruit. Until our ancestors figured out how to use tools, their meat-eating was probably confined to scavenging and opportunistically catching smaller animals, just as with our closest genetic relatives like chimpanzees.

Fire, not murder

The idea that meat eating was entirely responsible for developing larger brains is predominantly wishful carnism. This is an idea some people want to be true to help suppress their ethical qualms about our treatment of animals. I'm not sure it would in any case, but there is no really solid evidence for it. For a start, it involves a bit of circular reasoning. Regularly eating a lot of meat, especially of larger animals, wasn't really possible until humans figured out how to make and use tools. They used these tools in a uniquely human way, not

only to kill prey, but to process their carcasses. Given that advanced tool-making is often given as one of the defining points of homo sapien intelligence, the fact that it was necessary before we ate larger amounts of meat should make us question the underlying hypothesis.

Having an additional source of nutrients, especially fat and protein, would be helpful, especially in times of scarcity. During periods of extended drought or other difficult climatic conditions when plant foods might be scarce, eating animals might be the only way to stay alive. That is very different, however, to saying it is necessary. Even today, when we look at communities with poor diets, usually due to extreme poverty, it is common for people to advocate eating more meat as a way to improve their nutrition. While this might be true as an isolated point, the reason these communities' existing diet is poor is that it lacks calories or variety. In either our evolutionary ancestors or communities in poverty today, a mostly plant-based diet would be a healthier and certainly kinder way to provide basic nutritional requirements.

The best science suggests that our harnessing of fire was more consequential in aiding our brain development by unlocking additional food sources and nutrients. The brain is mostly fed on glucose, so this would have included plant starches and natural sugars. Human digestive tracts are much longer than those of true carnivores. Our digestive tracts were even longer before the harnessing of fire and the easier nutrition cooking provided to us. The ability to get nutrients from plants more easily enabled our guts to become smaller, allowing for more physiological resources to be put towards brain development. Looking back on prehistoric times is rarely easy; maybe we'll have more knowledge in the future, but for now, the hopeful claims of people saying meat "made us human" are unwarranted. Justifying modern humanity's terrible treatment of animals cannot be laid at the feet of our prehistoric ancestors.

Tree dwellers

Forward-facing eyes are a strange one, but it comes up. Like most animals, humans have two separate eyes that enable depth perception. There is a theory that prey species' eyes are wider apart to allow better peripheral vision to see attackers, and that predator species' eyes are closer together for more accurate, close depth perception. So far, so good, and this tracks with general trends in the evolutionary world. Where it gets muddled is in thinking that if you don't have eyes on the sides of your head, that makes you a predator, or vice versa. Again, we return to Aristotle's oversight: theory without looking at the actual world. Starting with our ape cousins, we could list many species that have forward-facing eyes and are primarily or solely herbivores, or ones that have eyes on the sides of their heads and are carnivores. Depth perception is advantageous for many things, such as swinging through branches, leaping over the landscape, and snatching a lovely fruit before someone else does. Eye placement is clearly not a clear evolutionary sign of any single trait. Humans, like nearly all primates, have forward-facing eyes primarily because they or their ancestors lived among the trees.

Evolution

Overall, the science is pretty clear that we have to go a long way back to a time when our ancestors ate herbivorous diets like those of the mountain gorillas. As for human anatomy and our evolutionary diet, we have been omnivores for millennia. Our anatomy is predominantly that of a herbivore, but with adaptations to better enable meat eating. Before our advanced tool usage, we used sporadic and costly hunting techniques such as persistence running and cliff driving. From our biology is seems that over the longer term, we opportunistically

supplemented our diet by scavenging. Humans were eating meat well before they harnessed fire, and therefore had to deal with a higher parasitic load from decomposing meat. Our stomach acids are quite strong and are similar to those of animals who survive almost exclusively on carrion, or what is called "risky meat", like hyenas and vultures. This makes sense when we look at human anatomy; we simply don't look like predators. We are unlikely to have been able to have animal products as a large portion of our diet until we started to use weapons, especially projectile weapons, and advanced group hunting techniques. There is clearly an evolutionary reason that qualified dietitians tell us to limit how much meat we eat, and make sure our diet is mostly composed of fruits, vegetables, legumes and whole grains to be healthy.

There is the question of how much we must be limited by what our ancestors ate. Around the globe, people's average daily meals usually contain at least one of the amazing variety of foods that only became available to the rest of the world after the European invasion of the Americas in 1492: corn, potatoes, pumpkins, tomatoes, peppers, peanuts, beans, and, of course, chocolate. Should we avoid these foods because our ancestors had never seen a potato or pumpkin, or just simply enjoy having access to them? Humans living in developed societies have an environment where a wide variety of food is superabundant. This is fairly unique in human history. It gives us the ability to make choices about what we eat, and this includes ethical choices. Nutritional science tells us we can live healthily on many different diets, including entirely plant-based diets free from animal products. Indeed, most nutritionists and nutritional bodies say that the majority of people would benefit from moving towards a more whole-food, plant-based diet. Using biology to justify our treatment of animals in our food systems is not consistent with modern biological or dietary science.

Once you strip away what people would like to believe out of habit, you are left with a simple truth of profound ethical importance to the world. We have the freedom to use our conscience in deciding what, or whom, we eat. We can contribute to making a kinder world…if we want it.

8. Humane

Question

What about backyard chickens?

Alternatives

What if animals were farmed humanely?

Summary

Chickens, perhaps even more than any other farmed animal, have been abusively bred to be production machines. The breeds of hens in our farming systems have been selectively manipulated to lay hundreds of eggs yearly, ten times more eggs and larger ones than their wild forebears. This is only one facet of a torturous regime that is inconsistent with health and quality of life. Life in a backyard would almost always be better than a factory farm, but hens cannot escape the fact that their bodies have been bred to suffer. If you care at all about the suffering of these friendly, inquisitive creatures, the best policy is to eat something else.

Discussion

The industrial factory farm is one of the cruellest creations of humankind. It's not meat-eating itself, but the sheer quantity of meat people consume and the relentless push to make it cheaper that have inevitably led to factory farming. There is a perverse cycle: creating a more industrial system that sacrifices animal welfare leads to cheaper animal products, and cheaper animal products lead to people consuming more of them, feeding and intensifying the industrial system. There is much talk about historical human progress, and while there are many rising indicators of human ethics and well-being, for animals, a different story is unfolding. There have never been more animals living in factory farms, and the conditions of their lives have trended towards ever more confinement, more intensive genetic meddling, earlier slaughter, and less autonomy to pursue their natural desires.

Economics over ethics

A widely viewed debate about the ethics of eating animals started with the side defending the eating of animals with a statement that went something like this, "We don't support or want to defend the factory farm". To avoid talking about factory farming in discussing the real-world ethics of eating animals is to reduce the practical consequences of the discussion almost to irrelevance. In the United States, the percentage of animals raised on "humane" farms is below 1%. For pigs, chickens, ducks, and increasingly cattle, the number of individuals on farms leading anything like a decent, natural life is a rounding error.

It is economics, not ethics, that governs the life of farm animals. The inescapable consequence

of billions of people wanting to eat cheap meat every day is that for each of these people, a community of animals has to endure life in factory farms before their, literally, premature slaughter. Industrialised animal agriculture and the universal meat-heavy diet are modern creations wholly dependent upon each other. To abolish the worst aspects of factory farming, to meaningfully reduce the suffering and vast environmental footprint they cause, animal product consumption would, at a minimum, need to be scaled back to pre-industrial levels.

Some remarkable surveys in developed nations have shown wide support, often around half of the population, for banning slaughterhouses and factory farms. People will say they want animals to be treated better and even say they want to eat fewer animal products, though usually for their health, but people also don't like change or paying more for things. So in the place of consequential action, they fantasise about impractical fixes that they aren't morally serious about enough to think through fully, much less implement. People talk about more humane farms as if they could be a "drop-in" alternative for factory farms, providing a win-win outcome of humane meat for relatively similar prices. Neither part of this win-win dream is true. The best these farms are currently providing is slightly less cruel meat at prices much higher than standard factory-farmed products. For decades, factory farming corporations have been optimising and refining a system built on the subjugation of every animal interest to profit. Anything resembling a traditional farming approach will never be able to compete with the scale and efficiency of these huge international conglomerates built to churn out animal parts and secretions.

Hypocrisy

Even among the rare animal product-consuming people who think much about humane farming, very few of them are even vaguely consistent in what they buy. It is actually a strange thing to be vegan and have so many people ask you questions like "What about if we treated animals better?", but when you ask how often they buy more humane alternatives, the answer is usually a blank stare. This has actually improved slightly since free-range eggs and "certified" products have become more common. They do often have some significant improvements in welfare over alternatives, but they are also limited in their scope purely by economics. Why people who eat meat regularly bring up the discussion of humane farming, which they don't seem to want to pay very much for or go to any effort to make happen, remains a mystery. It's like their fantasies about humane animal farming creep into the real world just enough to absolve their conscience about what is actually going on. There are many nice fantasies we can have, but surely it is what we do and pay for to happen in the real world, where animals daily suffer and die for our food, that counts morally.

Backyard farming has an emotional appeal, as it tries to replicate the stories we liked to read as children about how animals are farmed. Mother hens clucking happily with their chicks under their wings, a rooster on a fence crowing to greet the sunrise, the happy piglet on some grass, the smiling cow with a flower in its mouth and calf by her side. These fairy tales are often replicated on the outside of the packaging of animal products. Inside the packaging, however, is the reality of a dismembered animal that experienced many cruelties and had an unnaturally short life before it was transported to face the horrors of a slaughterhouse. Many of them have never known consistent family or relationships, have never been allowed to express their natural behaviours, or have seen the sun except perhaps when crammed together as they are being transported to their death. Pigs, cows, roosters, large fish- there are very few animals that can fit into the backyard farmer ideal, but then backyard farming is more about bucolic fantasies than any serious solution to the widespread suffering of farm animals.

Out of sight, out of mind

Back to the poor chicken, perhaps the most widely abused animal in the world. If you ever wonder about the scale of factory farming, think about the fact that there are more individual chickens in Europe than the top 100 wild bird species combined. If you are thinking of rehoming an animal from a factory farm that would otherwise go to slaughter, whilst a noble idea, it comes with various health and often mental issues for the birds. Corporations with profit, not hen welfare, in mind, have bred the modern factory-farmed hen. Wild chickens lay one or two dozen eggs, split into two clutches each year. The modern factory-farmed chicken has been bred to lay 10-15 times this amount, averaging an egg every day. The eggs they lay have also become significantly larger. This takes a terrible toll on the hens' small bodies, leaching calcium and other vital nutrients. Animal sanctuaries that take in hens from factory farms often give the hens hormones to slow down their egg production and give their bodies a chance to heal, though this isn't a healthy long-term solution either. Chickens can live for up to 20 years, but egg-laying factory-farmed chickens are killed when they are younger than two years old because, in industry jargon reminiscent of machines, "their production falls rapidly". In other words, their reproductive systems and bodies are spent, and they are slaughtered so some unfortunate younger hen can take their place.

The brothers of these egg-laying hens don't escape a cruel fate either. They are worthless to the industry, so they are immediately killed. The chicks are killed en masse, generally by being fed through a grinder (called maceration or shredding) while still alive or by suffocating/gassing. Note: these horrific methods are considered the "more humane" ways of killing male chicks and are recommended in Australia by the RSPCA. The Royal Society for the Protection of Animals is the primary body certifying welfare standards for animal agriculture in Australia. They certify 90% of chicken products sold under the brands of our major supermarkets. Allowing fast-growing breeds and grinding male chicks alive are just two of the cruelties that they allow to bear their stamp of approval. The Royal at the start of their name is perhaps the first hint as to how progressive the RSCPA are with respect to farmed animals, but more revealing is that their certification logo has a dog/cat paw in the middle of it. They perpetuate the older standard of animal welfare societies, which were mainly concerned with the treatment of cats, dogs and other pets we share our daily lives with. This attitude, the very definition of speciesism, allows other animals to be consigned to live in factory farms. I've seen footage of the conditions inside an RSPCA-certified piggery, and if anyone were to keep their pets in such conditions, the RSPCA would call for their prosecution. Animal welfare standards often have specific exceptions for farm animals, because apparently, cruelty is fine when it keeps meat cheap and corporate profits flowing. Consumers, in turn, enjoy the cheap animal products and ask few questions, the answers to which they don't want to hear anyway, because they might trouble their conscience.

In backyard farming, the problem of too many male birds doesn't go away. Roosters aren't as placid or useful as hens; they are often noisy, fight and of course don't lay eggs. Roosters can also live up to twenty years, but are instead mostly slaughtered in backyard farming at 3 to 4 months, before they start to mature. The hens are also generally slaughtered by serious backyard farmers as their reproductive systems start to slow down. Backyard farming may alleviate the intense confinement and cages, but it still involves slaughter and often much of the physical suffering.

Factory farms and slaughterhouses are terrible places, and that is even with some oversight by the government and the occasional activist breaking in and documenting conditions in them.

The unregulated, unseen nature of backyard farming might, on average, be better, but it can also go more awry. Amateurs keeping chickens purely for economic and production reasons risk having chickens suffer more painful deaths, neglect of their welfare, untreated diseases, lower standards of care, less protection from predators, and hidden abuse. Paying a vet to visit a sick chicken makes little sense if you have the animal for partly economic reasons. Suffering does exist on a scale, however, so despite possible wider variations, raising backyard chickens should mean an average improvement in hen welfare.

Bucolic fantasies

As a solution to the vast industrial system of factory farming, how scalable is backyard farming? In Australia, the average consumer pays for twenty-five to thirty broiler chickens a year to be raised and slaughtered on their behalf. A small family of four or five people might need to slaughter around 120 chickens a year to maintain the average diet. This would obviously mean a larger flock than this to maintain breeding numbers, and some for eggs and so on. Chickens are less than half the meat Australians eat, so we would need to add a variety of other beings to this hypothetical backyard as well, ponds for fish, stables, milking facilities and so on. A nuclear family would need to maintain a reasonably sized farm to sustain anything like the current levels of animal product consumption. How is this going to be done in the small suburban yards and apartments that today's increasingly urbanised and concentrated populations live in? This is all part of the reason most humans historically didn't eat as much meat as we do now: it simply wasn't possible before refrigeration and factory farms. If you want to argue for maintaining the modern animal-product-heavy diet, then you are arguing for maintaining factory farms.

Perhaps technology can provide a way out of this ethical dilemma and enable us to go on as we are without having to change? Cell-cultured meat, precision fermentation, and molecular farming: there are currently a handful of technologies that could hypothetically remove animals from factory farms and allow people to continue eating animals at current levels. None of these is yet proven at any scale, and until this happens, we will not know if they can compete on price with the industrialised animal agriculture system. We also have little knowledge of whether the products they will produce will be comparable to current products in texture or considered acceptable to consumers. The resistance many people and countries have had to genetically modified foods is perhaps an example of the resistance that animal proteins produced by unfamiliar technologies could, and probably will, create.

Ethical simplicity

People who aren't vegan often get the idea in their head that being vegan is hard or complex, but this is just unfamiliarity and habit speaking. As a long-term vegan, I generally find it simple: did the food come from a plant? Yes, then om nom nom! To be an ethical animal-product consumer seems harder. The primary thing you need to know is not what to eat but how the thing you are eating was produced. If you eat animal products in packaged food, go to restaurants and cafes, and eat with friends, family and colleagues, it seems there would need to be a lot of research and questions raised about how the animals were treated. I can imagine long discussions with waiters and other people who provide food to you. Backyard farming isn't going to change much of what happens when you purchase animal products outside of your house. If you want to live in a more ethically consistent manner, the simpler and more effective path would just be to go vegan. When talking about ethics, these sorts of practicalities are relevant but not the core of the story. Taking a sentient being's freedom away, using its body

for profit and production, disrupting their life and family, and prematurely killing them has to be oppressive.

Habit can blind us to our agency, that every day we are making powerful choices about other sentient lives. Through our daily consumption choices, at restaurants and supermarkets, we directly affect animals, whether they experience more or less pain. We affect the lives of others for better or worse, even if we aren't aware of it, because we never see or interact with them. Veganism is part of engaging with this wider ethical reality, of a hope that humans can transcend being a narcissistic and oppressive species.

We can do better than to turn our backyards into more places to oppress and slaughter animals. Paying to outsource oppression and slaughter, however, as most people currently do, is even less ethically acceptable. Luckily, we have a simple choice we can make to escape this ethical quandary. By joining the growing millions living happy and healthy vegan lives, we can be part of a movement showing the way to a brighter shared future between human and non-human beings.

9. Food

Question

Why do you eat things that look like meat?

Alternatives

Thinking that every vegan alternative is made of tofu. Thinking all vegan alternatives have unnatural ingredients.

Summary

If you are offended by someone happily eating a veggie burger or sausage, and not by billions of animals suffering in slaughterhouses and factory farms, perhaps you need to reconsider your ethical framework. Vegans are generally more concerned with the ethics, not the aesthetics, of what we eat. If people are bothered by food that hasn't involved the factory farm and slaughterhouse, then it is those people, not the vegans, who need to change.

Discussion

If carnists are so offended by vegans eating veggie burgers and sausages, this begs the question: why aren't meat eaters eating things resembling animal parts? A rissole, a burger pattie, a sausage, a bolognese, even a steak, none of these things exist in the form people eat them in nature. If animal products are so naturally delicious and appealing, why aren't there restaurants everywhere giving it to carnists the straight flesh? Raw severed pig's leg, anyone? Maybe just leave a live rabbit on the table for the diners to kill and process themselves, especially without tools. Instead, animal flesh is sold after removing the fur, skin, feathers, scales, bones, organs, head, tail, hooves, draining most of the blood and then shaping, spicing, marinating, saucing, texturing and burning. We really need to ask why carnists won't eat things resembling animals?

Our long history of alternatives

We should start with a history lesson. There have been vegetarian sausages for a long time, certainly since the 19th century. During the First World War, what were called "peace sausages" were created due to rationing and meat shortages. Though primarily made of soya, they would sometimes contain traces of meat. Vegetarian burgers have a much longer history, with a 14th-century recipe book talking about how to make Broadbean patties. Tofu is at least over 2000 years old, and soy milk was being produced as a byproduct not long after. Seitan, one of the most popular meat substitutes made of wheat gluten, was mentioned in China in the 6th century. In the early 18th century, it featured in an Italian cookbook. It was commercially available in the USA in the late 19th century. Centuries ago, China was the originator of most mock products, which were useful for Buddhists looking for vegetarian meals.

Milks made from plants also have a long history in the human diet. In English, the word milk has been used with respect to plant-based milks for at least eight hundred years. Almond milk was popular in Europe in the Middle Ages, especially useful for Christians who abstained from all animal products on religious days. In the Middle East, plant milks were popular, with an Arabic recipe for Almond Milk dating back to 1226 CE. The first record of soy milk in China dates from 1365. Native Americans were making plant-based milks from hickory nuts, walnuts, and pecans before Europeans arrived in North America. Coconut milk has long been a popular ingredient in cooking around Asia for thousands of years, with the first reference to it in English in 1698.

Mock meats and plant milks are certainly nothing new, but there seem to be people who are suddenly very worked up about them. Conservative politicians aligned with animal product producers have been alarmed at the rise in consumption of plant foods, and so have tried to ban the use of terms like milk, sausage, burger, yoghurt and so on. In some cases, like Canada and South Africa, they have been successful. In Turkey, they have even banned the production of vegan cheese alternatives. Why this is so triggering, and why a movement against these products emerged in the early 21st century, is an interesting question involving commercial interests, conformity, masculinity, resisting modernity, and culture wars.

Reclaiming words

Interestingly, the word meat didn’t originally mean animal flesh; originally, it just meant food, and then more specifically, substantial, hearty food. It wasn't until the 19th century that it completely replaced the wider usage of the term, coincident with an increase in the consumption of animal products. Before refrigeration and factory farming, consuming animal products in the quantities now common was unrealisable for the average person, especially those living in cities. This is evident in most cultural cuisines, which were historically primarily plant-based. The diets of most countries only became so animal product-heavy relatively recently, so much so that the definition of meat changed to mean only animal flesh.

Back to animal products looking like animal products, carnists seem unreasonably precious about terms here. We don't want to spoil any delusions, but most fish don't have fingers, and buffalo don’t have wings, though we don't see anyone get upset about these terms. Cheese, butter, sausages, milk and burgers. Most animal products go through production processes that alter them significantly from their natural look and state. What humans seem to like is cooking, combining, mixing, shaping, flavouring, texturing, and cleverly creating different culinary experiences. These processes are the same used with plant-based foods. Tofu is an excellent example of this: some people try tofu raw and find it unpalatable. You could say the same about most starchy root vegetables like potatoes, a foundational part of the global diet. You need to do some preparation for the deliciousness of potatoes to reveal itself. I know a few hardcore people who like to eat raw tofu, but then I once knew someone who ate raw brown onions like apples, so there's no accounting for taste. Everyone else I know who enjoys tofu adds some salt and pepper, or a marinade, cooking it in various ways, adding maybe a dash of chilli or soy sauce, then some veggies and carbs on the side, and suddenly you have a dish that provides plenty of nutrition and flavour. Tofu does come in a wide variety of textures, so it takes a little experimentation with the softer and firmer varieties for the right dish. If using it as an alternative protein, try the firmer varieties.

Decentering meat

People often mentally focus on animal products when they are only part of what they eat. I read a news story about a group of men who went on a camping trip together, and they said it had been a meat fest. They had collectively consumed something like 50kg of meat on the trip. Later in the story, it was noted that they had eaten more than 50kg of vegetables on the trip, no doubt with plenty of bread and other plant-based foods. They didn't describe their male bonding session as a vegetable fest, even though it would have been more accurate. Take your standard burger, that carnists with nothing better to do complain vegans need to come up with some alternative name for. Like many other meals, the flesh in most burgers is just part of the total nutrition and calories. Take one of the most commonly eaten burgers in the world, the communion wafer of modern consumerism, the Big Mac, three-fifths of it by weight are non-animal ingredients: bread, oils, sauces, lettuce, onion, pickle, and so on. Generally, if people are just eating a burger, called a rissole when I grew up, the patty is flavoured with herbs and spices, vegetables are then added such as onions and capsicum, and then it is finished with flour or breadcrumbs. All burgers are seasoned, then grilled in oil, to further change the texture and flavour. With most fast food, the meat is only a part of the final product, or it is so heavily processed and flavoured it barely resembles or tastes like animal flesh would have naturally. If vegans replace the meat in any of these dishes with some plant-based protein source, mainly for mouth feel and texture rather than flavour, we still get a pretty similar end experience. Why people get offended by this, and how they can find it something more worthy of getting upset about than slaughterhouses and factory farms, is hard to fathom.

What people who go vegan often realise is that it wasn't the taste of meat that added much to food, it was their practical use as an ingredient in a meal, especially their texture, fat content and protein. I find texture particularly important; a burger without a dense patty is a little too easy to chew through. Humanity has spent centuries coming up with different recipes, like the burger, and vegans see no need to ignore this culinary history when we can continue mining it for pleasure. Everything an animal product brings to a meal can be replaced with other things that have similar properties. If we swap a few ingredients and then add the same spices and flavours and cook it in a similar way, we end up with something that ticks the same pleasure boxes for us. How well do plant-based alternatives mimic animal products? Some of the commercial products can be almost uncomfortably similar, but most of the time, when cooking at home, they are not exactly the same, but pleasurable in a related but different way. If you've ever met people who argued passionately about which of two similar products is better, say Coke or Pepsi, Android or Apple, Vegemite or Marmite, you realise some of our preferences are pretty arbitrary and often inconsequential. After you've had a sufficient break from animal products, your tastes and expectations will adjust; personally, I don't compare things anymore because it's been decades since I ate animal products. You couldn't look into a busy vegan restaurant and know it was any different to any other restaurant, as the carnists who accidentally walk into them sometimes find out. You will see people ordering and enjoying food, talking happily with friends, full of the same joy of food and life.

Beyond meat

When it comes to replacing animal protein, we have a wide array beyond the mighty tofu. Beans and lentils are the easiest, cheapest and often healthiest drop-in replacements, but there are also nuts, seeds, grains, mushrooms, seitan, soy derivatives and other alternatives from the wide and diverse plant kingdom. There is a range of commercially made products that are increasing in quantity and quality. They are designed to be like-for-like replacements for

animal products in a meal and are especially helpful for people making the transition. If someone wants to start having plant-based meals a few times a week without much fuss, what could be easier than swapping in some plant-based chicken strips into their usual stir fry or tacos, or some veggie mince into their bolognese, chilli or shepherd's pie. These vegan alternatives are getting better and more varied all the time as veganism grows and becomes more commercially profitable. People often prejudge plant-based food as boring, but blind studies show that people like the taste of plant-based alternatives more than they expect. Eating food without animal products at the centre is more of a mental shift for many people than any other aspect of the change. As we all did for our current diet, perhaps unconsciously at our family kitchen table, we need to learn a way of eating. To eat a vegan diet, we need a little relearning, finding what foods we like and don't like from the ever-increasing number of vegan options out there. We need to experiment with different plant-based recipes and options. Most of the work is done if we can figure out a handful of staple dishes that form the core of most people's diets.

Above all, people asking why vegans enjoy a veggie sausage are missing the point. Nobody goes vegan because they object to the texture, shape or flavour of animal products. People mostly go vegan because they object to the violence and oppression inherent in animal products, to boycott a system they see as cruel, environmentally damaging and unnecessary. A lot of vegans do avoid products resembling animal foods because they have uncomfortable connotations for them, and that is fine. Other vegans are happy eating anything so long as it isn't contributing to factory farming. Personally, I enjoy these products and see them as clear evidence of how little we need to give up to end factory farming and live more compassionately.

There are many things we could get offended by in the world, but we need to have some sense of proportion about what actually matters. Finally, to repeat the point I made above, if people are offended by others happily eating veggie sausages, and not by billions of animals suffering in slaughterhouses and factory farms, they need to reconsider their ethical framework.

10. Natural

Question

Eating meat is natural

Alternatives

Killing and death are part of nature. What about the food chain? Lions eat meat.

Summary

Whether something has been done for a long time does not define whether it is necessary, just or compassionate. Consider all of the violent practices humanity has engaged in throughout the centuries. We might call many of these practices natural, but that is another question as to whether they should be perpetuated. Ethical progress will, on some occasions, require us to question our natural instincts and even nature itself. Nature, however, is complex and does not express itself only through violence, as some seem to believe. Empathy and kindness have been quieter but still powerful forces in evolution, especially the evolution of social species like humans. Each of us contains the possibilities of our evolutionary inheritance; we can make choices about what parts of our nature to perpetuate. A reverence for the natural world is vital in pondering the way forward for our species, but so too is a reverence for our highest selves, as they are expressed through philosophies and ethics. It is not in the preferencing of either our natural or our philosophical selves that the mutual flourishing of humans and the natural world will lie, but rather in their reconciliation.

Discussion

As much as humans have long wished for an ordered, moral universe, one that makes sense, the laws that govern the universe are mathematical and amoral. Good things happen to bad people; bad things happen to good people. Our fate is in some part governed by the elegant but soulless laws of physics. Humanity made up things like karma, heaven and hell to give us the impression of a just universe to shield ourselves from the uncomfortable truth that the control we have over our lives is limited. Hard work, intelligence and diligence are all potent factors in deciding what sort of life we will have, but fate often comes in and overrules them all. It would be nice if the universe had some sort of innate justice, but it does not.

The amoral universe

Science and philosophy have long known that what happens in nature is not necessarily right or just, and hence philosophy has a concept called the “naturalistic fallacy”. To say something is natural and consider this a moral or intellectual defence of it is not enough. Massive outbreaks of deadly diseases used to be common; to intervene with modern medicine is not necessarily natural, but it is surely the most moral action available. Cannibalism, slavery,

warfare, patriarchy, oppression and all manner of atrocities have long and fairly universal histories in all larger human societies. Studies on human cannibalism show we have been eating each other almost as long as we have been eating other species. Our ancestors were practising cannibalism over a million years ago, well before we evolved into homo sapiens. Is claiming cannibalism as natural a valid ethical defence of it? What about murder? Should a murderer be able to use the fact that people have always murdered each other as a defence in a court of law? If the "natural" defence doesn't apply to murdering humans, then why should it apply to us murdering other species? As vegans, we don't think our part in causing suffering is absolved by the fact that other people do it now or have done it in the past. Causing unnecessary suffering to sentient creatures requires a higher ethical justification than appealing to conformity or habit.

What about lions?

A common refrain here might be, "But lions eat meat!" Confusing the ethical nature of human and non-human animals has a long history. For hundreds of years, various regions in Europe put animals on trial for crimes ranging from murder to property damage. Most trials involved farm animals, and there are cases involving pigs, bulls, cows, horses, donkeys and mules. The trials took the same course as they would for human defendants, and if found guilty, the animal would be publicly executed. In one alleged case depicted in 1457, a mother sow and her piglets were put on trial for killing a child. While the piglets were acquitted, the mother was found guilty and executed. Wild animals that killed people were not put on trial, but insects and rats could be for damaging crops. If found guilty, they would then be exiled, or the church would be asked to intervene through exorcisms or incantations. Though not the subject of a trial, in the US case from 1916, an elephant lashed out at her trainer after he hit her with a hook, and crushed the man. A crowd of two thousand people turned out shortly afterwards to watch Mary the elephant be hanged from chains suspended on a crane.

The reason we no longer put animals on trial in the modern world is that we have a greater understanding of the fact that animals lack moral agency. As complex as the inner worlds of many animals are, often displaying empathy and compassion, they lack the higher abstract reasoning, rationality and communication skills necessary for a human-style moral framework. Of course, as acknowledged by our courts of law, not all humans have the capacity for full moral agency either, such as young children and the legally insane.

Returning to the fact that people often bring up lions among the countless predatory animals they have to choose from, our early nature documentaries have a lot to answer for their focus on lions, or more usually groups of lionesses, hunting. Lions have evolved to be obligate carnivores. Even if lions did have the moral agency to question their diet, they would be unable to make the same sorts of choices omnivores like humans are able to make about where to get nutrients. Another behaviour that lions have evolved is infanticide. When a lion defeats another lion and takes over their pride, they will often immediately kill all of the unweaned cubs in the pride. This forces the lionesses to become more fertile and allows the lion to immediately start propagating his own genetic material. If someone believes that lions eating meat somehow justifies the same behaviour for humans, how would they feel about someone justifying infanticide using the same logic? Moral agency is the key to our understanding here. The complex morality humans are capable of is one of the aspects of the human species that is to be most celebrated.

Modernity and nature

If there is a higher meaning in the story of our species, it probably lies somewhere in our collective ethical and intellectual progress. Humanity has made significant, though patchy, progress in many areas, including law, justice, democracy, medicine and philosophy. We did not guide this progress by appeals to what is natural, but by questioning what is good and just. The ethics of our relationship with non-human animals should be a fundamental part of our conversation about human progress. The fact that we have treated animals badly for so long is no excuse for perpetuating that status quo. Continuing to participate in the oppression of animals, especially farmed animals, is not an unchangeable part of our nature, but rather a choice we make.

A respect for nature is obviously a good and important thing, especially given the limits of our knowledge and our poor history of intervening in natural systems. Even if eating animals is natural, to call the modern diet "natural" or the factory farming system "natural" is to render the word meaningless. It is almost a cold joke to call it natural when one of the primary drivers of the destruction of the natural world is the modern animal farming system. People who hunt wild animals with their own hands or with tools they made themselves might be able to make the claim that they are doing something natural, but that sort of system is no longer universalisable. Hunting in natural ecosystems is never going to feed billions of people meat multiple times a day or week. How we eat meat requires an unnatural system. We have long ago turned our backs on the wild, breaking the natural food chain and jettisoning our place in any sort of cycle consistent with the evolutionary system. The unnatural, oppressive animal confinement system of barbed wire, cages, and slaughterhouses; the controlled breeding of species; the pasture, which is the primary cause of deforestation; and the third of crops grown for animal feed- these are unnecessary and primary things we need to transcend if our species wants to reclaim any sort of positive, compatible relationship with the natural world. Due to the modern industrial farming system, the majority of birds by mass in the world is composed of chickens. Well over nine-tenths of land-based animal mass is composed of humans and their livestock. Again, to appeal to nature in justifying this system is to render the term "nature" meaningless.

Beyond the food chain

The food chain, some simple words that lead people so deeply astray. People imagine this simple structure with humans at the top, and everything else in a chain beneath it. If we think this is a natural order of things, what do we do with the knowledge that, before humans started using spears, tigers probably ate more humans than the other way around? Tigers, lions and other big cats may eat hundreds of people each year. Sharks, crocodiles, bears, wolves, leopards, Komodo dragons, anacondas, hyenas, and even our doggy best friends nibble and gnaw on quite a few more. Again, the long human history of cannibalism also makes things more complicated. Then we have the mites, mosquitoes, ticks, fleas, lice, leeches and flies that regularly prey on humans. After we die, our corpses would naturally be picked apart by scavengers, microbes, bugs and so on. We probably started burning and burying our bodies because we were uncomfortable with this process, and maybe we didn't want animals getting a taste for our flesh. There are also tiny beings that live in places like our eyebrows, and bacteria that inhabit our bodies. Indeed, there are so many microscopic organisms living in and on our bodies that it is believed that anywhere up to half of our total cell count is microbial cells. Where does all this place humans in the mythical food chain? A food web might be more accurate, but this probably also undersells the full complexity of how countless species interact

with each other. The fact that an idea like there being a food chain, big fish eat little fish, has persisted for so long in our consciousness is a pointer to how much people prefer simple ideas over understanding the complexity of reality.

We can reimagine the human role in the natural world and the meaning of our individual lives in relation to it. Human higher consciousness hands us unearned power and, therefore, potential responsibility. Killing, death, disease, whatever evils there are in nature, as human beings, we are able to reflect on them and even potentially intervene in them. Imagine humanity as the great caretaker species of our world. There are more positive ways humans could generally interact with the non-human world. We could bring healing to other species, lessen the impacts of disease and disaster, and make this planet a kinder place for more beings to exist. For other animals, we could try to be like the benevolent gods we have always imagined, while always being careful that we do not possess the imagined omnipotence of gods. We can build our philosophies on a reverence for the evolutionary systems of life, instead of using them as an excuse for limiting our circle of compassion.

The naturalistic fallacy

Nature can be beautiful and awe-inspiring, but just as easily be cruel and arbitrary. This is because the mechanisms that govern material reality, the laws of physics, are amoral. The cosmos, being as a whole unconscious, cares not for good or bad. Amid all the hopes and dreams of humanity to live in a universe that makes sense, that is fundamentally good and cares about them, a void stares back into us, blank and impassive. The evolutionary system that created what we call nature is unfathomably intricate. The endless forms most beautiful around us are for many of us a great part of the happiness of our lives. Being amoral, though, this system is just as capable of causing intense brutality, suffering and ugliness.

There are times when it is appropriate to appeal to nature, and other times when it makes little sense. We might say we prefer what is "natural" in some product we use. Natural in this sense means something akin to harmony with evolution; shorthand for the fact that these products have a long lineage of interacting within our ecosystems. We would therefore assume them to be less likely to have undiscovered properties and side effects. Appealing to what is natural in this respect is a practical claim, because the things humans create interact with and become part of natural systems that are vital to the health of all life; systems that are vulnerable to disruption and generally beyond our complete understanding. Appealing to what is natural about ethics is a very different claim. Ethics are an emergent property of consciousness, rather than an inherent structural element within nature. They are grounded in and enabled by evolved properties of sentience, the ability for sentient beings to have positive and negative physical and emotional experiences of existence, but they then transcend the physical universe.

Ethics extends into the immaterial realm of ideas. They are products of our intellectual and philosophical selves. An example of this might be the concept that a human being should not be subjected to cruel and unusual punishment. Although rooted in evolved mechanisms like pain, this claim extends into the concept of common human dignity. It takes levels of intellectual abstraction to draw a line from the workings of the natural world to concepts like universal human rights. Utilitarian calculations of pleasure and pain can get us some part of the way towards human rights, but eventually such calculations lead us to places that feel morally repugnant. Take the Ursula K. Le Guin story, where a single child's suffering is required for the rest of the society to enjoy a better standard of living. Adding up the pleasure

and pain of this society and deciding that this was a positive outcome is a conclusion that only psychopaths and perhaps some economists would agree with. The concept of slavery is another area where an economist might make a utilitarian calculation that weighs costs and benefits, and find that most poor people would be better off as slaves to rich people. People who have experienced slavery, even in its less harsh forms, would generally come to a different conclusion. The partly intangible concept of freedom, of personal autonomy, would often see them echoing the words spoken before the American War of Independence: "Give me liberty, or give me death".

Interestingly, what we now call human rights were previously called natural rights or natural laws. The use of the word natural here was meant to embody the idea that the divine universe had embedded in it ethical laws that could not be overridden by power. Starting from an almost invariable cultural context of belief in a created universe, thinkers mistook evolved human traits like sociability, fairness, mirror neurons and empathy as the fingerprints of an ethical creator. The very need for the concept of human rights, however, comes about because our ethics are neither clearly apparent in nor enforced by nature; if there are fingerprints, they are faint and obscure indeed. Even our theologies must in some ways reckon with the world as it is, for there are limitations on our ability to ponder our existence from outside of its walls. Neither the atheist nor the theist can ignore the philosophical ramifications of the fact that pain, bad, and evil are highly correlated words. The natural world, that which exists outside of ourselves, is the focal point that anchors our ideas, around which our ability to communicate coherently depends. It is not, as those previous thinkers believed, either god's creation nor god itself.

To say something is natural is not the end of a discussion; it is just an important fact within that discussion. Many of us have positive connotations of the word nature, but in its amoral totality, it is not something to be universally celebrated. The brutality in nature has no inherent meaning or positivity, even if that brutality might lead to what seem like positive outcomes. The majesty and beauty of a carnivore in full flight, the structural niche they have made for themselves in productive ecosystems, cannot be easily disentangled from the horror and pain they cause. Instead of being our leader, brutality in nature is in some ways our greatest intellectual and ethical challenge. We have both the ability to perceive the injustices and cruelties in nature and the power to intervene to make nature less brutal. We must recognise that we are powerful actors. The choice we have before us is what the parts of reality that our actions can and do touch will be like. What will be the legacy of our passing through time and space on the ocean of sentient experience? To act, to do nothing, to be or not to be, every choice and non-choice has ethical consequences, some of them profound. The universe can be kinder and more just, including for other animals, if we make positive choices. Living an ethical life asks more of us intellectually than conformity to nature, of unquestioning obedience to the world we were born into. Progress happens when we rethink the way things are, as far as we can from first principles, and imagine better ways things can be.

A more ethical universe is a lofty goal, a heroic challenge for humanity that requires the flourishing of the best within us. To transcend our limitations, to outgrow our myopic selfishness and embrace the complexity of the interconnected reality of life, is a worthy challenge of our higher consciousness. Such lofty goals begin by taking pragmatic, powerful actions in our daily lives. By changing how we consume, especially what we eat, we can vote to balance and heal the natural world. Our full individual and collective ethical potential shall only start to be realised when we acknowledge our interdependence on, and our place within, the grand family of life. Veganism is a jumping-off point for a new conception of humanity’s

role within our complex evolutionary world.

11. Eat

Question

But what can vegans eat?

Alternatives

Being vegan is hard. Being vegan is expensive.

Summary

Most people already eat a variety of plant foods, and they make up the majority of the calories they consume; so they've already got a great starting point for a vegan diet. Anyone who believes that millions of vegans are wasting away trying to find food hasn't met enough vegans. Vegans come in all shapes and sizes, from slim to voluptuous, athletic to wiry, couch potato to powerlifter. Vegans do have far lower rates of obesity than meat-eaters, but we aren't all skinny. Veganism is about compassion, not self-denial or purity. Most people have access to an unprecedented variety of foods, so it has never been easier to make more compassionate choices.

Discussion

When you tell someone you are vegan, they picture their own diet with animal products removed and get confused about what would be left. Of course, most people already get around half their protein and the majority of their calories from plant foods, but for some reason, they don't see it that way. Animal products seem to form the psychological centre of people’s meals, especially for males. For most people, moving to a plant-based diet only requires changing a handful of ingredients. For animal flesh, for instance, most people eat products almost exclusively from four sources: chickens, cows, pigs and fish. So you could become a vegetarian, largely by removing 4 ingredients. If you then remove eggs and products made from cow’s milk, you have cut out the majority of animal products in the average diet. By changing 6 ingredients, you could be following a predominantly vegan diet.

A world of choice

A quick Google search tells me there are 20,000 plant species that people eat. Well, the first search result did. Another result said it was 300,000 species, then one said 80,000; you get the idea. The exact number of edible plant species is unimportant; we can just say there are a lot. There are thousands of fruits, vegetables, grains, nuts and pulses that we have never heard of. Many foods unfamiliar to us are staples and delicacies in other cultures. Most people eat a limited subset of the wide variety of plant foods available and mistakenly assume that is all there is, but there is a world of plant foods out there we have yet to explore.

Ask any healthy, long-term vegan, and they will tell you they eat a greater variety of foods since going vegan than they did before. Unfortunately, some people who try a vegan diet just remove animal products from the picture of what people eat, in line with the picture of the standard diet they unconsciously inherited from their environment. A plant-based diet then unnecessarily becomes a diet of self-denial, of less variety, that is far less healthy and interesting than it should be. It is probably fine, in the early stages of transitioning our diet, to just remove some ingredients from our kitchens and plates, but to set ourselves up for success, we should soon embrace a healthier way of eating. For all the problems surrounding eating animal products, if we spent our lives learning a diet based on them, they would play a role in our diet's nutritional profile. By reimagining what a healthy plate of food looks like, we can maintain or improve the nutritional power and sensual delight of what we eat. People who thrive on a vegan diet are those who have educated themselves on what healthy plant foods they can add to their plate to make it nutritionally complete and delicious. The Vegan Society website is a great place to consult for recipes and nutritional guidance. Some vegans may take more time in making this educational transition than others, but given our diet's important role in our physical and mental well-being, it is always a worthwhile long-term investment to make in ourselves.

Repairing the food pyramid

Most of us will be familiar with the concept of the food pyramid that governments often release. Few people, though, know or suspect how much the business of animal agriculture has been influential in creating many government nutritional guidelines. The advancing science of nutrition, however, cannot be completely denied. For decades now, we have seen foods like tofu, beans, nuts, and other alternative proteins start to appear alongside their animal product counterparts in nutritional guidelines. Veganism does not upend the food pyramid but adjusts it in a way that will be largely familiar. Whole grains, vegetables and fruits continue to create the foundation and majority of calories. We replace other parts of the pyramid with some of the wide variety of plant-based foods high in proteins, healthy fats, calcium, iron and omega-3s, etc. We are not intent on upending the food pyramid, but repairing it. Anyone eating a diet recommended by the world’s peak nutritional organisations will already be eating in a way resembling the plant-based food pyramid. They just need to replace the animal products in their diets with nuts, seeds, beans, legumes, grains, fungi, tofu, tempeh, mushrooms, soy, seitan, fruits and vegetables. Ingredients play a role in a given dish, and we can quickly learn to replace the textures and flavours we desire. It is similar to nutrients, we adjust the sources of them, the protein, fats, iron and so on, making sure we are eating foods optimal for our personal goals.

Milk is a good example of the variety of vegan foods that we can enjoy when substituting animal products. Instead of a single type of milk taken from the mouth of calves, vegans can choose from oat, soy, almond, macadamia, cashew, rice, hemp, quinoa, coconut, and many more, including blends. In my local supermarket, there are also high-protein, barista, organic, high-calcium, flavoured and other versions, so you can try as many as you need to in finding one that is right for you. Almost every common animal product has a plant-based version for those who would like them, from plant-based cheeses, marshmallows, milk chocolate (some dark chocolate was always vegan-friendly), condensed milk, mayonnaise, yoghurt, haggis, black pudding, bacon, jerky, salami….you get the idea. A diet reliant on these “mock” products isn't as cheap as eating more beans and lentils, but eating too much of these products, vegan versions or otherwise, isn’t nutritionally optimal anyway. They are out there, though if you need them, and can be found online, in health food shops, and increasingly in regular

supermarkets.

Some vegans identify as “junk-food vegans”. They would roll their eyes at all of the pontification about healthy eating here and say that veganism is not a diet, and they are correct. Veganism is a philosophy about the human relationship with other sentient beings, one that aims to reduce our contribution to their suffering. How healthy our diet is doesn't really change those equations. Junk food vegans will centre their diet on animal-free convenience products, such as plant-based meats and dairy products, or even what we call "accidentally vegan" convenience products, sweets and snacks. This type of diet can also make the transition to veganism easier, as we don't have to change the practical shape of our diet very much after going vegan. Of course, this option wasn't available to older vegans, and still might be difficult for people living in vegan-alternative deserts. If you have the opportunity, this type of diet is still a huge win for the planet and animals.

Back to the future

Vegans have a saying, "Eat beans, not beings". Eating a diet comprised of a large number of alternative products can get expensive, while missing out on health benefits. Rice, beans, lentils, whole grains and starchy roots have been the basis of human diets for millennia. They are still the primary parts of many traditional cultural diets, because they are the cheapest, most versatile and healthy foods you can find. They aren’t always the quickest or most convenient to prepare compared to modern ultra-processed foods, but whatever our diet, that is something we should be moving away from. By embracing cooking and considering the time spent in nurturing ourselves as a good investment, we can reclaim our personal sovereignty from food corporations that don't care about animals or us. These, often multinational, corporations are happy to perpetuate cruelty to animals and manipulate consumers. People buying their products adds to their share price, and they don't care about their other effects on the world. Ultimately, food is an incredibly personal journey. It’s up to each of us if and how we integrate convenience products into our diet. The animals you spare from factory farms don't care if you can be a junk food vegan, a whole foods plant-based vegan, or somewhere in between.

One of the healthiest diets ever studied is the Whole-Foods Plant-Based Diet. Many of its recipes are based on traditional world cuisines. Before ultra-processed foods reliant on oil, sugar, salt and deep frying, people put flavour into foods with herbs, spices, skilful cooking and quality ingredients. Whatever amount of time you are willing to invest in learning how to cook a WFPB diet will be a win for your pocket, the animals, your health and that of your loved ones. Creating and sharing tasty, healthy plant meals is a personal skill that will reverberate positively into your relationships and the world.

Habits and routines

We forget about how much of our diet is routine and habit. Habit can be our enemy in making positive change, but it can quickly become our friend in maintaining it. Adopting a positive lifestyle change, like following a vegan diet, will often seem more daunting than it is, partly because people fear change itself. This is despite the fact that most of us will have experienced how new habits, once acquired, quickly become as automatic and easy as old habits. Once we take a positive or negative direction in our lives, it soon starts to build its own momentum, so much so that we can't recognise the old self.

As you embrace a vegan diet, there will be a short period of adjustment. In this phase, you'll be learning and trying new things, scanning ingredients to look for what is animal-derived, and checking out the local vegan-friendly restaurants using the Happy Cow website and application. Very soon, the core knowledge you need will start to coalesce, and the vegan diet will move from the unfamiliar to the familiar. The scale of changing your diet is also not as large as we might think. People generally have a rotation of regular dishes, frequent the same restaurants, and buy more or less the same list of items when they go grocery shopping. Once you get the hang of these core changes, you will have achieved most of the necessary progress. This might be very quick if you are motivated to learn and research new things, but you can also take a more relaxed approach. For people who like to cook, the perfect place to start is putting together a good roster of regular dishes, often veganised variations on the ones you already make. I like to eat from a variety of cuisines; my staple dishes involve pasta, wraps, veggie burgers, stir fries, salads, curries and soups. Now and then, I will cook something new from the Internet or a recipe book. Whether you are just starting to cook, or are a foodie, there is an infinite world of vegan blogs, video tutorials, meal plans, shopping tips and recipe suggestions out there. As with learning most things, a good, free place to begin is by consulting the oracle of the Internet. To find restaurants, type in "vegan food near me". To find ingredients, try "vegan alternative to". To find recipes, try "vegan" followed by the name of your favourite dish. There are also free vegan meal kits, websites that help you go vegan, online communities you can consult for advice, vegan social groups you can go along to, the awesome Happy Cow to find food wherever you are in the world, and hopefully a vegan or two in your life you can consult with.

There is a meme about eating vegan that makes light of our tendency to overcomplicate things. At the top, it has a box that says, "Is it from an animal?" Beneath the box, there are two arrows, one that says "Yes, then don't eat it" and the other that says "No, then eat it". Obviously, there's a little more knowledge required, but it makes a point. People often overcomplicate a change, and this becomes a barrier to the change or an excuse not to make the change. Millions of people across vastly different cultures, at all stages of life, have gone vegan, so you can too. Most vegans hope and believe that one day this will be the norm, and it will be a better world for us all.

A new hope

Veganism is about an ethical evolution for the whole human race. We believe that one day our age will be seen as a strange and dark place with respect to our treatment of animals. People in the future will scarcely believe that the cruelty and oppression inherent in animal agriculture were not only legal but commonplace; that so many tried to justify, or gave little thought to, the suffering of billions in factory farms and their murder in slaughterhouses. Our cruel treatment of animals is also unnecessary, which only adds to its immorality. We can eat beautifully and healthfully without participating in this oppressive, destructive system. We can play a part in bringing about a better shared future for all animals in this world, human and non-human.

12. Not much

Question

I don't eat much meat

Short Question

Alternatives

I am mostly vegan. Someone tells you they recently ate a vegetarian or vegan meal.

Summary

Whether you think you eat much meat is partly related to who you compare yourself to. Americans and Australians consume 2 to 3 times the amount of animal products compared to the global average. An American who "doesn't eat much meat" might be considered an avid meat consumer in Japan, or even in America, before the factory farm changed things so drastically. Someone who eats meat less than once or twice a week can probably claim they aren't eating much meat. Everyone else should say something more like "I don't eat as much meat as my red-faced uncle who drives a big car". Most vegans appreciate the positive aspiration to eat less meat, but it still implies victims. Fewer animals in factory farms means less suffering in the world, but every animal unnecessarily slaughtered for food is an individual tragedy.

Discussion

People who say things like "I don't eat much meat" or "I just made a great lentil soup" to a vegan are often trying to connect in some way. So let's start by saying that this is generally positive on some level, and we should encourage such statements. If someone is reducing their meat consumption or is switching to plant-based milk, this will have positive ramifications for their health, environmental footprint and, usually, animal suffering. Not eating much meat, however, is a relative term. People often base their idea on what is a "normal" level of animal product consumption at the specific time and culture around them. In some countries, average meat consumption is up to 20 times higher than in others. If we are in a culture that eats globally and historically high levels of animal products, when someone says "I don't eat much meat", they might still be eating quite a lot. It is also a vague statement, nothing as direct as "I only eat meat when I am at special events" or "I only eat animal products one day a week", so we are left to guess at what it means. Perhaps it means people have reduced their consumption, such as eating smaller portions. Perhaps they have swapped red meat for chicken and fish. Perhaps they feel they eat less meat than some of their family members. From a vegan point of view that sees all animal product consumption as unnecessary and

unethical, this reduction still looks like eating a lot of animal products.

The small animal replacement problem

Perhaps unintuitively, eating less meat doesn’t mean eating fewer animals. How many animals suffer as a result of your diet depends on what species of animals you eat, and at what life stage you eat them. When people consume the body of a veal calf, lamb, kid or piglet, many more must endure the cruelties of our animal farming system because, obviously, infants and children are so much smaller than adults. Chickens, some of the most abused animals in the farming system, are very small relative to pigs or cows. Each person regularly eating chicken flesh and eggs requires a sizeable flock to be kept on their behalf, like a shadow self that suffers on their behalf in factory farms and slaughterhouses. Multiplying this size flock by the number of people who want to eat chickens results in tens of billions of hens imprisoned at any given moment. Fish are another common substitute for other animal products for people concerned about the health of their diet. Fish species vary in size, but many that humans eat are quite tiny, especially sardines, anchovies, shellfish and many crustaceans. As human overfishing assaults our marine ecosystems and the breeding cycles of every target fish species, the average captured fish becomes ever smaller, meaning more fish must be killed in a destructive downward cycle. People who eat less meat by swapping large animals for smaller animals will eat more animals, and thus potentially cause more suffering.

Collateral damage

Land-based animal farming doesn't just involve the oppression and slaughter of target species, but requires the exclusion and killing of non-target, native species. This begins with the deforestation involved, to remove imagined predators, to remove competitor species for animal fodder or water, for often preemptive, poorly researched disease control, to stop animals digging burrows and holes, to prevent them from damaging fences, and the list goes on. While the number of non-target species killed on land is in the hundreds of millions each year, the scale of this killing is dwarfed by the killing of non-target species in our oceans. When you eat any animal from the sea, the animal you actually eat might be a minority of the ones killed to get that sea creature to your plate. All industrial wild-fishing methods are functionally indiscriminate. Longline fishing involves trailing hooks on 10 to 100-kilometre-long lines through the sea; bottom trawling involves heavy cages being dragged across the ocean floor, destroying everything living or otherwise in their path; drift nets or "purses" are huge nets thrown onto target-rich areas to suffocate and crush whatever is in the area. Killing non-target species is called bycatch: wild sentient creatures who suffer and die just to be tossed away as refuse. In drift net and bottom trawling, bycatch often exceeds ninety per cent of all killed animals in industrial wild-fishing. The death in bycatch is often for no purpose at all. The period during which industrial fishing gear is being actively used is often just the start of the death and carnage it will cause in our oceans. Drift nets and long lines often escape or are cut off their moorings and boats to spend decades drifting our oceans as "ghost nets" and "ghost lines", indiscriminately attracting and killing ocean life for no purpose. Discarded or lost fishing gear will finally break into smaller pieces, becoming a leading cause of plastic pollution in our oceans, including microplastics. It's not just to feed humans that this assault on our oceans takes place, but to feed our pets, farm animals, plants, and, horrifically but almost absurdly, our land-based fish farms.

So if meat reduction means someone switching their diet from pigs and cattle to chickens and fish, or even from a wild fish to farmed fish, it can mean more animals in factory farms,

crushed in nets, harried and herded into slaughterhouses, impaled with hooks or suffocated. Not eating much meat can end up killing more animals. Vegans hear this a lot from well-intentioned people, but it isn't something we can necessarily celebrate.

Diet and rationality

I have often spent time with numerous people who tell me they don't eat much meat. This might be when travelling together, at work, at conferences and so on. I can't help noticing that they seem to eat a lot of animal products, every day, at both lunch and dinner, sometimes even breakfast, regardless of whether there are readily available good alternatives. Even if such people gave meat a break for a meal, which is usually only breakfast, the animals certainly don't get a break, as the meal seemingly has to feature eggs or dairy. There is something more than taste and logic going on here. I've met meat eaters who refuse to eat vegetarian meals, and vegetarians who refuse to eat vegan meals, though both groups probably happily eat such meals accidentally reasonably often. I have on a couple of occasions, been out with people who don't know me well, and I've offered to buy a round of snacks for the table. I then ordered finger food like fries, chips, spring rolls, pakoras, cocktail samosas, nuts, and so on, but on none of these occasions did people question the food, and they just ate it happily and thanked me. I think if I had declared, "I will get some vegan snacks for the table", it would have gone differently, probably with people feeling the need to go and buy their own snacks. A bowl of cereal for breakfast is a vegetarian meal, a bowl of channa masala, daal, bread and rice is often vegan, but if you labelled them as such, many people with an animal product-centric idea of their meals would avoid them. If you asked someone whether they are emotionally attached to having animal products at every meal, they would probably say no, yet here we are. If people really do "not eat much meat", it might help break this level of emotional attachment; however, if they are just reducing portions or swapping species, it probably won't.

Vegetarian myths

The focus is often on not eating much "meat" because people consider dairy or eggs to be “deathless” industries. This is another sign of how divorced people are from the industries and practises they have paid for via their consumption over their whole life. Even people who claim some connection to these industries, "I grew up on a dairy farm" or "my uncle raises chickens", can often, with a few basic questions, be shown to be largely unaware of the cruelties which take place as standard practise in these industries. We shouldn't expect a better understanding from people who grew up in urban environments, and equate animal body parts and products more with their packaging than the sentient, emotional beings they came from. A short list of examples has to be made here, though people should take the time to confirm these things for themselves. Male chickens are killed immediately after their gender is detected, often fed alive and en masse into grinders. Their sisters go on to spend a life of suffering before being killed when their reproductive systems are spent at a relatively young age. Dairy cows are repeatedly impregnated to keep milk production high, which means the regular production of male calves that must be taken and killed. This is usually within a few days of them being separated from their mothers, but “humane” veal farms might let the male calves live a few months before slaughtering them. A minority of males will instead be castrated and dehorned without anaesthetic, allowed to grow for a year or two before being slaughtered for low-grade meat production. Females in the dairy industry are also, if needed, dehorned without anaesthetic, and kept alive only while their reproductive systems enable peak profitability. After milk production slows at a relatively young age, they are destined to be herded onto crammed trucks, for a journey during which they are neither fed nor given water, that ends in the trials

of the slaughterhouse. The dairy industry is a vast environmental and animal welfare disaster. These are just some of the cruelties and injustices that are an integral part of eating animal products, even beyond meat, in our society. If you are serious about contributing to a better world with your diet, swapping meat for eggs or cheese might mean fewer animals suffering, but many of those animals can suffer more.

The ethical and environmental case for dramatically reducing our global dependence on animal products is unassailable, despite people, out of habit and self-interest, trying to argue otherwise. According to our peak dietary bodies, average meat consumption in many developed countries has become too high. Health authorities consistently encourage populations to reduce meat consumption, particularly of processed meats, in favour of more fruits, vegetables, whole grains, beans, etc. Many developed countries would see significant environmental and animal welfare improvements by people simply following their peak nutritional authorities' dietary recommendations, not to mention human health. Agriculture is a world-dominating industry, and animal agriculture is the most unnecessary and destructive part of it, whether we talk about deforestation, species extinction, pollution or climate change. We can do a lot of good for ourselves and the world by eating a healthier diet of more plant-based, whole foods. The world's peak dietary bodies also confirm that a well-planned vegan diet is a healthy choice at all stages of life. There is no physiological necessity to eat animal products; if people are mostly doing this out of habit, then it is a habit we must collectively replace to tread more lightly on the earth.

Inculturation

If one had to guess what somebody eats without knowing anything about them, a decent approximation would be to look at what their parents eat. Our inculturation to a specific form of eating starts when we are toddlers. We don’t put much thought into how we came to eat what, or who, we do, but over our lives, we have been taught a specific cultural diet. We have learned a taste for particular things, become accustomed to a certain level of salt, sugar and fat in our foods, certain types of spices, and learned what foods are appropriate at certain times of the day. Cultures put their own largely arbitrary constructions around the very basic need to get certain nutrients into our bodies. We can see all the cultures around the world happily eating very different diets, yet many picky people would be very upset if they had to swap diets with a similarly picky person from another culture. No doubt if we had been raised in a different culture, we would have very different tastes and preferences. Diets are, after all, beyond the nutrients, pretty arbitrary. Yet if many people were forced to eat as a different culture does, they would be uncomfortable, resist, or possibly even angrily resist. It's irrational, but then most people live largely irrational lives that they have no desire to question. Vegans are asking people to change their diets for compassionate reasons rather than arbitrary cultural or aesthetic reasons, but we will still often face the same instinctive, irrational resistance. Diet is a pretty deep thing to change, so when people say they don't eat much meat, that might be as far as they can go without severing the links of the shared, arbitrary identity they mistake for their individual, consciously chosen self. If we wish to change this, it may not be through the rational mind we need to go, but doing things like exposure therapy to vegan food and thought, to slowly shift cultural perceptions and open up a crack to a different self, one that has the courage to look unblinking into an uncomfortable ethical reality that their consumption makes them complicit in.

Comparison is a large and not always productive part of our identity. When people say they don’t eat much meat, they aren't comparing themselves to their great-great-great-

grandparents' generation, which ate quite differently. While the world population has more than doubled since the 1960s, livestock production and consumption have more than quadrupled. Academics call the changes in diet that have happened in almost every country post-World War II the modern nutritional transition. This has been enabled largely by factory farms, fertilisers, pesticides and intensive breeding. People don't have a good understanding of this change and how much it has altered our world and our diets. Many people mistakenly think that meat has always been as central to their national cuisines as it is today. I have had conversations with people of varying nationalities who believe that not only is their national diet currently meat-heavy, but that it has traditionally always been so.

People from Spain, Japan and South Korea have all told me some version of, "My country is traditionally a heavy meat-eating culture", and on each occasion, I looked them up:

- Spain - Transitioned away from a Mediterranean diet, with one of the lowest per capita levels of meat consumption in Europe, to one of the heaviest via a 400% rise in average meat consumption since the 1940s.

- Japan - Transitioned away from a rice, vegetable and marine animal diet via a 700% rise in average meat consumption since the 1940s. For centuries, various types of animal products, including beef, chicken and eggs, were banned from consumption across Japan. These bans were only entirely lifted with the Meiji restoration and modernisation reforms in the 1850s.

- South Korea - Transitioned away from a heavily rice, vegetable and marine animal diet via a 600% rise in average meat consumption since 1970. In Korea, a country that has a proverb meaning "Living through the power of rice", meat has now overtaken rice as the most consumed product.

These countries are just examples of a global trend. Current levels of meat consumption around the world have increased dramatically alongside the spread of the factory farm, often replacing healthier, traditional plant-rich diets. Modern farming techniques and intensive breeding pioneered by heroic individuals like Norman Borlaug, along with a vast new range of pesticides and fertilisers, have increased production to the point that a global majority can now get more calories than they need. Obesity is now as much of a health problem in the world as hunger has always been. While this increase in the quantity of food and calorific availability is rightly celebrated, the quality and variety of diets, such as the traditionally healthy diets of places like Spain, Japan, and Korea, have declined in many ways. By being so much more dependent on animal products, there has certainly been a sharp increase in their ethical ramifications, for which there is yet to be a proper reckoning.

Evolving together

Moving to a better relationship with the earth requires large structural changes, but these can only be constructed on billions of individual changes. We live in a culture that has not adapted our individual behaviours to ever-evolving environmental and ethical realities, including those that modern technology and a surge in human population have created. This means that when we look at obvious facts, like that most of us are living lives far beyond the environmental

tolerances of the earth, or that the way we eat requires immense cruelty and oppression of other species, we cannot necessarily look to the people and culture around us for positive role models for change. Often, the opposite is true; instead of helping us to be our best ethical selves, we live in a culture that makes it easier to continue living in an unethical way. This means it will take an effort of will, and our character will constantly be tested if we try to make the significant changes needed to live in a more compassionate way. For many of us, these positive choices and changes might need to be gradual, as we reorient lives out of sync with our ethical ideals. Taking time is understandable whilst new habits are acquired and new ways of eating and thinking become embodied in our lives. Not making those changes, however, would be to turn aside from our authentic self, to a comfortable cultural construction that is a tyranny on other life.

In the end, we should generally try to be kind to people who hold out a hand towards us. "I don't eat much meat" is a statement of positive intention, and if properly followed through with, it will mean the ramifications of their lives on the non-human world will be less bad. We should have higher ideals for ourselves and our contribution to the world than less bad; we should be heading towards flourishing and a higher good. A better collective future awaits humans and animals beyond the factory farms, cages, barbed wire enclosures, slaughterhouses, and other tools of animal oppression that humans have created. Not eating much meat leaves these things that should never have existed in place. A collective evolution to a global vegan culture is too important for us to linger in the ethical purgatory of transitional phases. Be part of leading that change.

13. What about humans?

Question

What about human suffering?

Alternatives

You care more about animals than people. We should worry about humans first.

Summary

To think that one can only care about a single issue is a false dichotomy. Humans are complex beings, and most of us can and do care about more than one thing. Surveys consistently find that people who care about animals are more likely to care about human rights and the environment. The idea that we need to ration our compassion or love is a basic misunderstanding - widening our circle of empathy does not diminish, but strengthens it. People are animals too; human suffering is animal suffering; being vegan extends our compassion to its necessary and logical conclusion.

Discussion

What about human suffering? The premise of this statement is that some beings matter and others don't; that some suffering is legitimate to care about and some isn't. Humans are apparently at the top of this hierarchy, so high above all other life in every way that any consideration for other beings is ridiculous, even immoral. Such people appear to be arguing that so long as a human suffers in any way, we should not consider any other suffering, no matter how egregious and widespread. This means we should ignore the suffering of tens of billions of non-humans that huddle in factory farms and slaughterhouses, suffering we could relatively easily eliminate by changing parts of our diet, because this is the suffering of lesser beings. Few statements could outline human supremacy and speciesism more succinctly.

This way of thinking is consistent with animal agriculture. The treatment of animals in our farming system embodies the idea that even trivial human desires, like the preference for some ingredients over others, outweigh almost any rights a non-human being should have. The factory farming system takes everything from the animals within it, including the right to freedom, to life, to health, to family, and to live according to their nature. The usually unstated philosophy of anthropocentrism underlying animal product consumption is at the root of our oppressive relationship with all other life. Vegans want to bring this submerged philosophy into the light, so we can have a discussion about whether the current human treatment of animals is consistent with living ethically.

The call for dualism between humans and other species should be rejected not only on moral grounds, but also increasingly on the basis of scientific evidence. Social science has asked

questions about whether people who care deeply about animal suffering consequently care less about other ethical issues, such as human suffering. The studies show that the opposite is true, that the more people care about non-human animals, the more likely they are to care about humans as well. Kindness or its opposite appears to be a general product of our character that applies regardless of which species we interact with. This is backed up by criminal science, where animal abuse is highly correlated, and often predictive, of abusive behaviour towards humans. Misusing one's power over another sentient being again seems to reflect a person's character rather than some thought-through hierarchy of species sentience. Biological science has also, since at least Darwin, rejected the idea of humans as a completely separate kind of being. Science has superseded religious notions that we have yet to completely jettison from our culture, such as the Christian idea that humans alone have souls and that other animals were created for our use or dominion. The common evolutionary patterns we share with other animals in our bodies are so obvious that it is hard to believe that we failed to acknowledge them for so long; only a religious story that we needed so deeply to believe could stop us from seeing these common patterns. Modern DNA evidence has only more deeply confirmed that animals are our kin, and some of our very close kin. We share 98.8% of our DNA with chimpanzees, in comparison to the 99.7% we share with Neanderthals, with whom we could interbreed. The call for greater compassion towards non-human animals is based not only on moral intuition and common feeling, but on our ever-deepening scientific understanding of humanity's place within evolution.

Focusing on difference

There is a noticeable human tendency to focus on the difference between non-human animals and us, so much so that we could almost call it a cognitive bias. For many years I worked at a university and would attend lectures given for the public on a wide variety of fields. The number of times eminent academics from different disciplines would start a sentence with "The difference between humans and other animals is" was quite startling. I found it particularly noticeable because usually the words which followed the start of this sentence were some combination of obviously wrong, tenuous, incomplete or unknowable. Regardless of how poor the comparison was, the audience would inevitably nod along, as if it was so pleasant for them to be told they were better than other species, a premise they had already unquestioningly internalised, that some part of their rational brain was being disengaged when hearing a sentence that started with this premise. For centuries, humans were called "The tool users" until it was shown just how many animals use, and sometimes make, tools. The key difference between humans and other animals has shifted to various aspects of thinking, rationality, emotion, culture and so on, which one after the other have been shot down by behavioural biology. Many academics and writers would have saved themselves an intellectual dead end if they had listened to Darwin, who in the nineteenth century pointed out that the difference between humans and other animals was one of degree and not kind. Of course, when you tell people what they want to hear, that they are better and higher than others, you get a very sympathetic hearing. There is no doubt the human mind has unique aspects in the realm of abstraction and information processing, but the inaccuracy of almost all attempts to nail down the difference more specifically than this tells us more about the limitations and self-serving nature of our minds than it reveals about non-human animals. We have an incomplete understanding of our own consciousness and that of other animals; we try to clumsily point to the differences between them and us, but this is not knowledge, but rather a substitute for knowledge.

Moral consistency

We would find far more fertile ground in intellectual and ethical progress by focusing on the commonality between ourselves and other beings. Again Darwin was at the scientific forefront here, pointing to how similar our internal worlds were to those of other animals. We know a large part of the experience of other animals because human suffering is animal suffering, human emotions are animal emotions. The species in our factory farms and slaughterhouses experience feelings that we would recognise in ourselves. Other animals are capable of experiencing pleasure, pain, fear, hope, hunger, thirst, anxiety, depression, affection, curiosity, parental bonding, and a full gamut of emotions. To what level their experience is different to ours, even if in some ways their experience might be less complex, does not make them unworthy of our consideration. Like us, they are a sentient consciousness thrown into this shared existence, and primarily seek safety, security and happiness. In reclaiming our relationship with the animal world, we can look back to the origin of the word animal, rooted in the ancient Greek word anima, or soul. The commonality that this word represents should be the centre of our morality and philosophy towards all sentient life. Most of the ethical duties we owe to other humans, we already owe to them by their inclusion within the word animal.

Martin Luther King said, "Injustice anywhere is a threat to justice everywhere.” This is not only an ethical statement, but a pragmatic one: the simplest morality to teach and internalise is one based on consistent logical principles. Often, the first step in enabling wide-scale atrocities is to justify applying different ethical principles to the desired victims. A phrase pertinent and revealing to our current discussion is often used by perpetrators - "dehumanisation". Dehumanisation is a necessary step in overcoming our natural human empathy, one which can imagine what it would be like for us to be in someone else's circumstances. The percentage of people who score highly on the dark triad of personality traits, psychopathy, Machiavellianism, and narcissism, is significant and overrepresented in positions of leadership, but they are still a minority in society. To get the rest of society to behave badly requires a story as to why it is actually behaving ethically. Even some of the worst actors seem to need to believe this kind of story, and go into elaborate justifications as to why their behaviours were moral. When those advocating for war crimes are asked why they considered children, the elderly, non-combatants, or those who posed no threat as legitimate targets for violence, they usually try to justify their crimes as moral and necessary acts of self-defense. It is because most people are basically good and fair that these justifications are necessary. Given this, we would expect to see the same process of justification play out in our societal violence towards animals, and of course we do. The main justifications for violence towards animals have been summarised by Melanie Joy as "Normal, natural, necessary and nice".

The ideology of oppression

It has been said that one of the reasons for the change in human belief systems from the hunter-gatherer paradigm, which tended to respect nature and other creatures, and the grazier/farmer paradigm that subjugates other creatures beneath humans, is that the way animals must be treated to farm them can't be consistent with a level of respect. When you are beating an ox, or are taking a cow's children away to be slaughtered as you ignore their calls for each other, it wouldn't be psychologically comfortable for you to think of them as brother and sister beings. To feel better about our oppression of others, we must emphasise that they are less than us, and that our poor treatment of them is somehow morally acceptable. We see this lack of respect in many of the words we use to demean other people, which also demean animals. Whether it be to insult someone's intelligence, common sense, or their body shape, we

often use the names of species that we breed and use: you cow, turkey, goose, chicken, pig, ass, dog, bitch, and so on. This disrespect serves a purpose for us, helping us ignore our empathy in order to feel better about our treatment of thinking, feeling beings.

There have been studies in which people watch films of traditionally farmed animals playing and so on, and the researchers give the study participants a bowl of either animal-based or plant-based snacks to eat while they watch the film. After the film, the researchers ask the study participants to rate the animals on aspects like intelligence and moral worth. Those who watch the films while eating the animal-derived snacks rate the animals lower on all morally relevant measures than those given the plant-derived snacks. It seems that people know that there is significant animal cruelty in our farming systems and so need to justify their participation in this mistreatment by demeaning the sentience of the animals; however, they don't appear to do this consciously. The intellectual mechanism behind this is called cognitive dissonance, a state where a person has two conflicting beliefs, especially ethical beliefs, that must be reconciled. The carnist ethical conflict is fairly transparent: people know eating animals requires cruelty, while at the same time believing it is morally unacceptable to be cruel to animals. There are two paths towards resolving this dilemma: the first is to change our treatment of animals, and the second is to create an internal narrative that justifies not changing and continuing our cruelty towards animals. Too many people take the second, lazier and more selfish path that requires them to demean the sentience of animals. This is how powerfully our perceived self-interest perverts our thinking, often happening on a semi-conscious or subconscious level. Our brains will actively resist changes necessary to live more ethical lives, and thus, to be a more ethical person can take a sustained effort of conscious will and introspection.

A revealing phrase that one hears when describing a person or group as having been unjustly or violently treated is "They were treated like animals". This phrase falls very differently on the ear of someone who rejects speciesism, seeming to reflect an underlying violence and injustice in a society that is acceptable if it is targeted towards the appropriate victims. To look into the fearful eyes of a sentient being or to hear their cries, and to decide that you don't care about them, does not seem a wholly morally different action when directed towards one species or another. The human ability to feel positive and negative emotions, pleasure and pain, safety or fear, is inherited from our animal origins, not a product of our more recent higher consciousness. Speciesism also seems a short step away from deciding that some subclass or group of our own species requires less ethical consideration. Indeed, we don't have to hypothesise about this, as we can look back at the history of inter-human atrocities and see how many of them involve equating the targeted group of victims with some species of animal. If we were more morally consistent in teaching compassion towards animals, it seems likely to have a positive effect on our compassion towards each other. There is much to be said for fostering moral consistency, as Aristotle said, our morals are like a muscle that gets stronger through regular exercise.

Holistic healing

A plant-based diet reverberates positively out into the world in many ways beyond the lives of farmed animals. Livestock’s inconvenient long shadow is involved in almost every environmental problem, from a local to a global scale. The way we farm animals is one of the primary drivers of the destructive Anthropocene, contributing to air pollution, water contamination, land degradation, species extinction, deforestation, invasive species and climate change. The scale of the livestock industry is almost unimaginable, with pasture

covering over half the arable land of the earth. Only a few per cent of the remaining mass of land animals are wild creatures, with the vast majority being either humans or their livestock. Two-thirds of the mass of all birds in the world are now farmed chickens. The land on which grain is grown to feed billions of livestock animals can be repurposed to provide for people in the remaining food-poor regions of the world. Most of the communicable diseases that have plagued humanity throughout history have been a result of our contact with animals, including colds and flu, COVID, the black death, smallpox, Ebola, and AIDS. Somewhere between two-thirds and three-quarters of global antibiotic production is fed to healthy livestock, a reality that threatens to undermine one of the great human health breakthroughs. A better world awaits humans, not just non-humans, if we can turn aside from eating and using them for our own purposes.

To look into the eyes of a dog, a cow, or a child is to see something of ourselves looking back at us, wondering about us. Many animals share with us deep parts of the magical spark of consciousness; to justify diminishing or extinguishing that spark because they do not share our identity is an injustice. We are all earthlings, sharing this experience of existence, together. The great power we hold collectively over the lives of the other species of this world means that our moral choices require deep consideration.

Trying to live an ethical life can be difficult in a society that often profits more from us when we live unethically. Ethics asks much of us, requiring us to change habits and learn new ways of thinking that perhaps it would be more convenient for us not to think about. The separation from our conformist selves can also cause friction in our lives among the people who would prefer we validate their unethical conformity by staying in it with them. There is a higher realm of living, though, one that calls to us beyond the small world of human society and selfish desire. It is a life in which our goal is to continually widen our circles of thought and compassion, and help others to do so. Our collective intellectual and moral progression is bound up in the liberation of the oppressed, and we should look first at those of whatever species whose oppression we contribute to. We do not need to choose between being ethical towards humans or animals; indeed, the highest ethics requires us to choose them both. Thinkers throughout the ages have understood this.

Whilst there are slaughterhouses, there will still be battlefields - Tolstoy

Until we stop harming all other living beings, we are still savages - Thomas Edison

We can judge the heart of a man by his treatment of animals - Immanuel Kant

If you have men who will exclude any of god's creatures from the shelter of compassion and pity, you will have men who will deal likewise with their fellow men - St Francis of Assisi

By killing, man suppresses in himself, unnecessarily, the highest spiritual capacity, that of sympathy and pity towards living creatures like himself - Tolstoy

While we ourselves are the living graves of murdered beasts, how can we expect any ideal conditions on this earth? - George Bernard Shaw

For as long as men massacre animals, they will kill each other - Pythagoras

The greatness of a nation and its moral progress can be judged by the way its animals are treated - Mahatma Gandhi

Until he extends the circle of his compassion to all living things, man will not himself find peace - Albert Schweitzer

14. Can't

Question

But you can't eat that!

Alternatives

It's not vegan, but it is gluten-free. Can you eat bread, peanut butter, etc?

Summary

Non-vegans and new vegans focus on what vegans don't eat, whereas established vegans mostly focus on what they do eat. From the perspective of an animal-product-heavy diet, veganism may seem like a diet of self-denial. Vegans, however, see aligning our consumption with our compassion as the opposite of self-denial because it is about living in a way that expresses our better selves. Replacing a handful of ingredients is a small price to help heal humanity's relationship with the non-human world. Once we become accustomed to being vegan, a mental shift occurs where we cease to consider animal products as food and instead focus on the infinite variety of the world's foods and cuisines.

Discussion

Some vegans like myself weren't looking for an identity or a belief system; indeed, I didn't really mean to become vegan. I stopped eating animal products one at a time, as I found out about the cruelty inherent in each of them in turn. Refraining from eating them was the result of a deliberative process and conscious decisions, not an attempt to become "vegan". Nothing stops me from eating animal products, as embodied by the word "can't", except my concerns for the animals involved. Perhaps this seems like nitpicking; "can't" is only a word, but the fact that it is so often chosen over other alternatives seems to reveal that people are missing an important point. The choice of words may seem subtle, but it's important to frame veganism as an active, ongoing, thoughtful, powerful set of choices.

Something in the phrasing of the statement "You can't eat that" is revealing. After you have heard this phrase enough times, you start to wonder why people so commonly frame vegan dietary choices with the word "can't", rather than "won't" or "don't". The use of "can't" turns the phrase into something that sounds involuntary or not thought through. There are people who "can't" eat things, such as people with allergies, intolerances or taste aversions, but vegans are none of these. There are those who "can't" eat something because of the belief that doing so would cause them to fall out of favour with one or another higher power, or at least their community. This kind of performative renunciation or aestheticism, too, is not what veganism is about. Most vegans have eaten animal products at some point in their lives, so they certainly can eat them, but have consciously chosen not to.

Personal choices

Veganism is about our relationship with animals, not vegans. It isn't about "personal" choices, but rather the opposite. Veganism is about starting to take responsibility for the world beyond ourselves, and our contribution to suffering in it, certainly not purity or blind adherence to an arbitrary set of rules. Our “personal” consumption choices are rarely personal, as they ripple outwards into the world. Choices are certainly no longer personal when they have victims. What we “can’t” do is separate our lives and actions from all other life, for we are locked in an interdependent relation with it, one in which, as a human, we have inordinate power. In making choices about what to eat, we regularly and powerfully affect the world and the lives of others. If we could trace the origins of all the ingredients on our plates over the average week, they would span a vast area of the earth, involving thousands of individuals and complex processes to bring them to you. The sheer scale of agricultural corporations that feed billions of people every day means that there are many potential ethical concerns involved. The ethics of how we eat is a complex intersection of corporations, governments, billions of consumers, millions of producers, countless wild and farmed animals, and our global environment. The decision to follow a vegan diet is perhaps the most powerful way to claim our power and responsibility within this complex system.

Defining veganism

What exactly is a vegan diet, though? What do and don't vegans eat? The original Vegan Society, based in England, has a statement that most vegans take as the de facto definition:

"Veganism is a philosophy and way of living which seeks to exclude—as far as is possible and practicable—all forms of exploitation of, and cruelty to, animals for food, clothing or any other purpose; and by extension, promotes the development and use of animal-free alternatives for the benefit of animals, humans and the environment. In dietary terms, it denotes the practice of dispensing with all products derived wholly or partly from animals."

This statement is an excellent start, but it also needs to be thought through by each person. The Vegan Society, in its early days, didn't consider honey to be vegan. They then changed this stance and declared it a matter of individual conscience, but they then returned to not considering it a vegan product in the 1980s. This may even change again as more humane techniques for farming bees in the future are created. Veganism exists within a changing world, with cell-cultured meats, precision fermentation, new farming techniques and even the accuracy of many “mock” products creating an ever-evolving discussion about what should and shouldn’t be called vegan. Veganism must evolve as the world evolves, and not make the same mistake that many religions have, of fixing their morality at a point in time or on a set of ideas that lose relevance as the world around them changes.

As corporations that profit from factory farming diversify into the growing vegan market, it continues to complicate the ethics of food choices. Some vegans won't buy products from companies that get most of their income from animal products, while others see this as a way of incentivising those companies towards more ethical production. Palm oil production, or other products that cause major species loss and deforestation, are not considered by many to be consistent with veganism. Others see environmental concerns, or concern about a relatively small number of wild animals compared to the lives of billions in factory farms, as being of lesser ethical importance. This is one of many ongoing debates about antinomies within the vegan community, with compassionate and sensible people on all sides. People who are

unfamiliar with the diverse intellectual landscape of veganism often speak quite clumsily about it in black and white terms, such as "can" and "can't", but there are few ethical sharp lines in a changing and complex world.

There are people who intellectually agree with all the arguments about the ethical necessity of veganism, but think that a moratorium on eating animal products doesn't always achieve the best outcome for animals. Some of these people call themselves "freegans", people who combine vegan ethics with the vital issue of food waste. While a freegan will only purchase vegan products, they will eat animal products that would otherwise be discarded. This is often the motivation behind **dumpster diving**: rescuing and repurposing the vast amount thrown away by businesses, often when they pass or near an arbitrary "best before" date, etc. Environmentally and ethically, there is no benefit to discarding something when all the misery and resource expenditure involved in its production have already happened. So long as you are not helping create a market for it, you are reducing your environmental and ethical footprint by consuming it. While I admire freegans, like many long-term vegans, I no longer consider animal products to be food, and the idea of eating them provokes a disgust response.

Delving deeper

To complicate our ethical considerations further, there are people who call themselves ostro-vegans. Ostro-vegans consider only sentience - the level of conscious awareness and ability to experience things like pleasure and pain that a being has - as a factor in the ethics of their consumption. The terms plant and animal seem pretty clear in our minds, but evolution is more subtle than such black-and-white terms can encompass. Evolutionary science points towards a vast, complex web of interrelated life existing on many continuums. As far as we know, there is only one family of life on Earth; animals evolved from plants, and there are endless forms of life at each stage in this progression, both in terms of physical and mental attributes. Ostro-vegans delve into the blurry lines between species, between plants and animals, sentient and non-sentient, and draw the line of compassionate duty differently than vegans do. There are creatures called bivalves, such as clams and mussels, that lack a centralised brain. They can make simple movements such as opening and closing their shells, but don't appear to have any of the internal wiring needed for consciousness. Do these seemingly simple creatures require the same moral consideration as clearly sentient beings such as pigs, chickens, cows, and tuna? Ostro-vegans consider it ethically acceptable to eat bivalves, and perhaps find it an easier diet to follow than veganism, especially in terms of social conformity. Although they don't see the need to eat these animals, many vegans are sympathetic to the ostro-vegan approach as more ethical and considered than that of most others.

The journey towards an ethical life is similar to climbing an unfamiliar mountain: You see a peak above you, you climb towards it, and just as you think you are about to reach the summit, another previously obscured peak appears above. Veganism is not about ticking a list that offers ethical purity, but rather a path where we hope each step gets us closer to an ethical life than we were before. Veganism is about trying to make the world kinder for all life, not about self-denial or moral purity.

When people start on the journey of veganism, they will often accidentally eat an animal product. "Why has this got milk solids in it?" is a phrase one often hears from incredulous new vegans about products they wouldn't expect to have dairy in them. Sometimes, even when one has been vegan a long time, through accident or complacency, eating some animal product unfortunately happens. Some people get upset about this more than others, but from the

viewpoint of the universe, the ethics are less relevant. We should focus on what we do and consume 99.9% of the time, rather than expending too much energy on the final 0.1%, unless, of course, we enjoy doing so. It is the totality of our life that is important, not the occasional, inevitable errant step. We learn, we move on. Of course, there are those who deliberately eat specific animal products and refer to themselves as a vegan. Some see this as harmless, but I would say that the word "Vegan" has to mean something. When I say I am vegan in a restaurant or other setting, the cooks and chefs should have a clear idea of what that means. The definition is simple: no animal products, and cooks shouldn't have to have a twenty-minute conversation with each consumer to find out what it means to them. Though I do not think veganism should be overly dogmatic, neither should it allow itself to become a vague, meaningless term. Veganism is a clear political statement to others about our ethical stance towards animals. It is important to display an ethically consistent message, a clear narrative light, for people to follow. Hypocrisy is often the easiest and most damning way that moral authorities have been undermined in the past. What we say about ourselves, what we ask of others, should be consistent and clear. Whatever label someone attaches to themselves, vegan, vegetarian, pescetarian, freegan, ostro-vegan, or some other, they become a representative for that idea in the world. We all have a duty to represent the ethical labels we claim in a way that serves wider and higher purposes than ourselves.

Peanut butter?

Finally, for vegans there is a pretty simple test. Is it from an animal? Then don't eat it. For some reason, this is much more complicated in many people's minds. Some of the things that people regularly eat, but have never thought of as vegan, can be amusing. I've had all manner of things I eat be questioned as to whether they are vegan, including bread, pasta, beer, avocado, oat cream and peanut butter. This partly shows how little people understand their food, especially its ethical aspects. People conform; they accept the food their culture and family serve up, and don't question it. They often don't even know in much detail what ingredients or nutrients are in the foods they eat, much less the repercussions of their diet on the world. No one is born with this sort of knowledge; they must acquire it somehow, so only education can correct this. If we find people with relatively open minds, starting discussions about food and ethics will be good for them, animals, and the environment. We should start with the things we all have in common. Most people don't want to hurt animals or the environment. Most people, especially people following a relatively healthy diet, will already be deriving the majority of their nutrients and calories from plant foods. By starting to make the unfamiliar familiar with what vegans eat, we can start to give people another possible conception of their diets and themselves.

Focusing on what vegans can and can't eat mistakes the forest for the trees. Veganism is not a diet; it is a philosophy of compassion. People who mistake veganism for a diet display how little they understand its vital message for our world. Veganism is not about ticking some arbitrary boxes; it is about having a thought-through personal response to deep ethical questions about the way humans currently treat other life. What we "can't" do collectively is continue living in a way that depletes the shared living systems of this world. What we "can't" do is continue sending animals into slaughterhouses and factory farms, and think our ethics towards animals shouldn't be questioned.

15. Aspirational

Question

I am an animal lover

Alternatives

I'd love to be vegan but… I was vegan/vegetarian but…

Summary

Noble aspirations are fine, but when we reflect upon our lives, we will judge ourselves more by what we have done than what we wish we had done. In the process of self-actualisation, the most important step is to make our lives consistent with our ethical aspirations. We may love animals or wish there was less suffering in the world, but if we don't believe these things strongly enough to alter our behaviour, we need to question our ethical priorities. Kind thoughts, prayers, virtue signalling, and policing language can all be reasonable in themselves unless they are the main extent of your activism. Love, compassion and kindness must be active because it is the realm of sentient experience that ultimately matters, not your internal world.

Discussion

Veganism is an idea that has become more embedded in the mainstream in recent decades. Society has become more conscious, often uncomfortably so, of the ethical conversation around veganism and the treatment of animals. The world was only recently very different. Elder vegans will recount having to constantly explain their veganism at the most basic level; after all, this was a time when most people thought being vegetarian was about abstaining only from red meat. We had to spell v-e-g-a-n countless times; personally, I had to do this almost every time I went out to eat with new people. In developed societies now, most people are at least vaguely familiar with the term. It is now even common to bump into vegans in social situations, along with people who have considered veganism or even tried it. All of these are positive signs that veganism and the ideas it represents are on an upward historical trend.

We seem to be heading, though all too slowly, to the version of the future most vegans believe in: that the moral arc of history will bend towards justice for animals. Most vegans assume that a vegan world is eventually inevitable; that our collective ethical progress will take us beyond the oppression of billions of animals, of forcing them into factory farms and slaughterhouses. We believe that society will eventually be mystified that so many unquestioningly participated in such a vast atrocity. I have watched many eminent ethical thinkers be asked a question such as, "What do we currently think of as normal behaviour in our societies that future generations will look upon as barbaric?" I have seen similar answers from people like Noam Chomsky, Steven Pinker, Martha Nussbaum, and Richard Dawkins, who all said that our treatment of

animals was the most likely candidate among our current practices to be condemned by future generations. Sadly, few of these eminent thinkers have followed through with this belief to become vegan or even vegetarian themselves. When I met Peter Singer, I asked him how he felt about his conversation on the topic with Richard Dawkins, and Singer told me how hard it was for him, despite his high regard for Dawkins, to understand his cognitive dissonance in this respect.

Ethical Consistency

It would be very inefficient to think through everything we do in our lives; instead, we live mostly through habit and conformity. Most people do this with respect to eating animals; it is something they have always done but have never questioned. Here we get to a moral question: is it worse for someone to do something they know is wrong than to do the same thing without knowing it is wrong, whether that be through ignorance, apathy or some other intellectual mechanism? For the animals, their suffering is the same regardless of the intentions or knowledge in the mind of the person paying for their abuse. We might say someone who worries about the lives of animals in factory farms has a kinder personality, but if they do nothing to help those animals, then their effect upon the world is the same as that of an unkind or ignorant person. If our ethical framework allows us to contribute to animals spending nasty, brutish and short lives in factory farms and slaughterhouses, mainly because we can't be bothered learning how to eat or cook something else, then it is a very limited ethical outlook. People may look to the norms of the culture around them for moral support, and find justification in the fact that they are only doing what their family, friends, co-workers and much of society do, but ethics is not a popularity contest. The opposite is probably more often true: the most powerful and noble expressions of ethics are when people rejected conformity to the society around them and acted selflessly.

Moral imperatives

The fact that more people know about veganism is a good thing. We shouldn’t ignore the positives that this change in the societal narrative represents. Of course, we must try to ensure that the focus is on the animals and not on vegans. Many people will be happier shooting the messenger instead of engaging with the issue the messenger represents, but the opposite of engagement is often not argument, but indifference. Those who are willing to discuss animal rights or veganism, even if they defend a counter position, are in some way our allies in ensuring the topic is in people's consciousness. We push animal industries beyond the edges of our urban environments, out of sight, out of mind. Truth dies in darkness, and the darkness of factory farms and slaughterhouses is very deep indeed. By encouraging ethical discussion about the status of animals, we do them a service, because so long as it is a rational discussion, it is one we will ultimately win. In this world of minds closed to change, of selfishness and egocentrism, there are people who might be open to a positive change, but we need to make a good case.

Engaging people

Hope is often a double-edged sword. If a person starts explaining why they can’t be vegan, most vegans will instinctively want to help the person overcome their hurdles. Of course, the person might be more justifying not being vegan rather than seriously considering veganism, but usually the best policy is to give them the benefit of the doubt. It's easy to misjudge others' viewpoints and where the other person is in their current outlook; we all fall into stereotypes

and assumptions, so we can then misjudge the moment or our tone and come across as preachy or sales-y. Perhaps the first thing to remember is that it is very rare, no matter how well thought-through and expressed all your points are, that at the end of a single conversation, you will have converted someone to veganism. Sometimes being too good at arguing all the points can overwhelm people, and we might be better off listening more and focusing on one or two main points that are most important to the person we are talking to. Having a detailed, conversation-ending answer for every justification you have heard a hundred times before, drowning a person in facts rather than empathy, and ignoring their unique, complex emotional reality can all be counterproductive. We need to have the conversation the person needs and is open to, which helps them change their frame of reference, not the standard conversation we have rehearsed in our minds. We also often embark upon conversations we think would have resonated with us before we were vegan, without recognising that we all have different levels of openness to change in different contexts in our lives. There is not one conversation, but perhaps a different one for each person. It is helpful to remember the statement "We are not our audience".

Effective conversation

What will make people change? When people are asked why they became vegan will often give a very specific answer, for instance, they read a pamphlet, watched a video or were positively influenced by a person. No doubt these were pivotal moments, but there is usually a long process that leads to people being receptive to the right information at that moment. A foundation needs to be laid in each of us, a crack in the conformity of our minds opened for some light to seep in. A different world/self might need to be made conceptually possible before there is a chance for bigger change. Does someone even know about factory farms, or do they assume animals probably have reasonable lives in them, or do they think the way we treat animals might be wrong but don’t know what to do about it, or are they vegetarian because they instinctively think killing animals is wrong but don’t properly understand the death and suffering in the egg and dairy industries, or are they attracted to the idea of veganism but just need to know what steps to take, or something else unique to them. Chances to sincerely discuss our relationship with the non-human world are precious; we should not squander them with the discussion we want to have, circling debate, or giving people information overload. We have to focus on the person in front of us and how we can help their ethical journey, even if they don’t know they are on one.

Communication is hard because people are complex and unique; they are often so very different from us as to be almost unrelatable. Drawing broad lines here, some people will judge a discussion by its rationality; they are best reached via a clear, coherent argument, and too much emotion will make them feel they are being manipulated. Others are more sensitive to the interpersonal aspects of a conversation, too little emotion might come off as cold, facts aren’t inconsequential, but an emotional connection with them, and animals are more likely to resonate. People have different life experiences, cultures, sensitivities, and levels of tolerance for difficult topics. People also have psychological defence mechanisms, and many will instinctively turn away from discussions or depictions of suffering, perhaps as echoes or reminders of their own pain or trauma. So some people might be willing to hear the full horrors of animal farming, and others might need more of a focus on the positive alternatives to animal farming. People are also at different stages of knowledge about issues and varying openness to change; in short, some need to know why, but others need to know how. Blundering into a system as complex as the human mind without understanding it is usually a mistake. If someone says "I can’t be vegan", we have to start by listening.

Vegans and ex-vegans

One place where many passionate vegans can be short-sighted is in their attitude towards people who used to be vegan. “They were never really vegan” is almost a cliche in such situations. This way of thinking ignores many realities and circumstances in people’s lives. The most obvious is that sometimes people need a few attempts at making life changes, even ones they want and believe in. Perhaps people were undergoing something emotionally challenging while they were trying to become vegan, and might just need some healing and re-energising before they will be ready to try again. People’s motivations for going vegan also vary. Not everyone becomes vegan for animal rights or from a reverence for the non-human world. Some come to it for health, or because they were in a relationship or social circle that made it easy for them to be vegan. They might not see stopping being vegan as betraying the animals, because for them, it was never really about the animals in the first place. The attrition rate of vegans, especially those who aren’t motivated by ethical considerations, is high. When someone is vegan, many in the movement kind of think of that as a "tick", and if we focus on them at all, it might be about how we get them to become activists. Our movement focuses too much on getting people to become vegan and doesn’t do enough work on helping already existing vegans to be happy, healthy, socially connected and well-informed. Speaking about social connection, not all social circles are as tolerant of veganism as they should be. If someone is the only, or one of the only, vegans in their family, social circle, relationship, workplace or community, it is going to be harder for them to stay vegan than for others. We need to think about how we can help people foster a community that makes it easier for them to make ethical choices without negative social ramifications. Just being around a group of kind, committed vegans every now and then can be a balm for many people; it can help them feel less alone and different in the world.

Over promising

With health, a lot of vegans can promote unrealistic claims for the vegan diet. Literally, people will say that vegans never get sick. When I posted on social media that I was getting the COVID vaccine, someone commented that I should be immune to viruses because I was vegan. Some people don't even advocate taking a regular B12 supplement or making sure to eat calcium and omega-3-rich plant foods. Not only are these positions dangerous and empirically untrue, but promoting veganism as a miracle cure can lead to disappointment and disillusionment. The highest nutritional bodies in the world reaffirm that a well-planned vegan diet is consistent with good health at all life stages, and may bring some benefits, but the evidence for veganism as a panacea simply isn’t there. It should be enough to know, given all the environmental and animal suffering benefits, that we can live more ethically while still fulfilling our health needs, and can maybe be even healthier if we plan our diet well. Selling people a miracle cure might gain some temporary vegans, but they might also become vocal proponents against veganism when the magic fails to happen, or signs of some nutrient deficiency start to kick in. We want a movement for the long haul, and that means preferring to make long-term vegans over short-term victories.

Conclusion

Most people who become vegan only regret they hadn’t done it sooner, so we think people should get on board the vegan bus as soon as possible. Yes, people should go vegan, but most of us should also probably exercise more, sleep more, learn an instrument, use less plastic, ride a bicycle and meditate daily. The fact that we aren’t all living our best lives is not always

purely a moral failing, but a reflection of the fact that we have many competing priorities for our physical and mental energy. Our culture doesn't always make positive change easy; there are many people and things competing for our mental space and time, and not all of them care about us or the world. As vegans, we might need to be patient and consistent in setting a positive example, being kind, giving people space, and helping rather than convincing them. If you have a choice between dominating an argument or giving a positive impression of veganism, you might think about leaning towards the latter.

As much as we personally identify with veganism, it is not about us or our egos; we are speaking for the animals, and we have a responsibility to do it effectively. Some of the most vociferous, hardline vegans I have met seemed to put more people off veganism than draw them to it. Being right, coming from the moral high ground, is not enough; our egos can often be the main barrier between us and our connection with others. Almost any conversation about veganism is a chance to plant seeds that might bear fruit. Let us ensure in these conversations, we properly embody our message by exhibiting the compassion for humans that we are trying to promote towards animals.

16. Preachy

Question

Why are vegans so preachy?

Alternatives

The sadly ironic "live and let live". Each to their own. What I eat is a personal choice.

Summary

Like any large group, amongst millions of vegans, we will find people with varying social and communication skills. Even if a messenger’s behaviour warrants shooting, the message they present might be worth thinking about. How well or poorly someone presents an argument or idea does not necessarily tell us whether it is important and true. Ignoring our deeply unfair relationship with non-human life because we met someone emotionally unintelligent is to punish the wrong beings. You owe the animals on your plate the respect of taking your own journey into the ethical arguments for veganism, because what you choose to eat matters too much to those animals for you to wait until someone argues for veganism in a way you find appealing.

Discussion

Vegan Stereotypes

Vegans reflect the diversity of humanity, with all the normal flaws, biases and varying levels of emotional intelligence. There are sweet vegans, sarcastic vegans, nerdy vegans, cool vegans, and grumpy vegans; actually, most of us can be any one of these depending on what day you happen to meet us on. There are some vegans who have hostile and judgmental personalities, not only towards non-vegans, but also towards other vegans who don't live up to their expectations. These people think they are helping veganism; they even have a thought-terminating saying that is meant to justify their attitudes: "All activism is good activism". Yet, this clearly isn't true, and often their negative example can discourage people from listening to the vegan message or eating fewer animal products. You know if someone is a difficult vegan if they think of themselves as the "real vegans". As said, this is OK, there are many different personality types who are vegans, no doubt including some who exhibit dark triad qualities. The problem, though, is that people like to put other people into boxes that they assign qualities to. Vegans are still relatively few in number, and if someone hasn't met many vegans and meets a difficult vegan, they might assume that this is what all vegans are like. The box with the word vegan on it is tainted, and they won't look favourably on the concept of veganism. Veganism, however, is a philosophy about our relationship with the non-human world. No individual or group owns the concept; compassion towards animals is a universal ideal, and is not owned even by the Vegan Society of the UK, which gave us the word vegan

and the most widely accepted definition of veganism.

Anyone who has had bad experiences with a preachy vegan should try this social experiment: try saying you are vegan for a while, or tell your friends and family you are going vegan. You'll find that people on all sides of the topic can be preachy. You will experience the sort of repetitive conversations and reactions that vegans get all the time, the exact motivation for this text you are reading right now! Things have generally gotten better in this respect, and generally, most people are considerate; a few are even interested in knowing more about veganism. Some people, however, seem to have a major prejudice against veganism, along with most other forms of socially progressive ideas. That said, there are also many social progressives who have a major blind spot when it comes to animal agriculture. In the end, for all the preachy vegans in the world, there are many more people who get quite annoyed or angry about the idea that we should be more compassionate towards non-human animals; vegans are a personal affront to their way of living.

Many vegans have been in the situation of being out for a meal and enquiring about vegan options. A person, usually but not exclusively male, then starts bombarding them with poorly informed and often hostile questions. It’s actually worse than this in many social situations, as a hostile person is usually representing the majority opinion around the table. Most vegans will have sat at entire tables of people who have apparently never cared about the animals they eat enough to look into the reality of factory farming. Arguing against the mob is almost an impossible task. The problem is partly that some humans are more status-seeking animals rather than truth-seeking ones; if someone says something, what matters is not how intelligent or true it is, but whether the surrounding people are validated by it and cheer it on. It may be unfair, you may have intellectually and logically prevailed in most aspects of the conversation, but if you failed in the court of public opinion, you and the animals have not won. There is also the problem that when one person argues against a number of people, they usually only have a small percentage of time to present the opposing opinion. We may protest that ideas should be judged by their ethics and logic alone, but we know that is not reality; the medium is often more important than the message, and the people who speak the most often sway the day. Non-conformists are held to higher standards than the majority, and this is just part of life; so keep your poise, and bring the conversation back to the ethics of our treatment of animals, not vegans themselves.

Communicating across the divide

We still need to talk about preachy vegans. As vegans, most of us will have read the books and watched the videos; some of us have even heard the cries from within factory farms, and smelt the stench that farmed animals are forced to live in. We know and feel all of the emotional angst that preachy vegans are expressing at this unnecessary human-caused suffering. But we must also recognise that non-vegans haven't had these realisations, they live in a different emotional and intellectual landscape. Farmed animals to most people are not individual beings with their own hopes, fears and personalities, but rather just a blurry space on the edge of their consciousness. If animals are treated so badly in farms, they might reason, why would that be legal? Why isn't everyone upset about their treatment? Why indeed. So instead of seeing us as advocates for animals, they see a status-seeking person trying to win an argument with them, or even trying to emotionally blackmail them. They can't tell the difference between vegans and every other entity trying to inhabit a piece of their mind, like religions, politicians, marketers, influencers, salespeople, scammers and charlatans. Vegans need to recognise this reality, and consistently behave in a way that makes clear we are not just another group

selfishly promoting our own interests. By carrying ourselves in such a way as to resonate with the compassion in others, rather than their defensiveness or sense of shame, we can most effectively advocate for the animals. This may require some internal work, but then learning to communicate in a kinder, more empathetic and ethically consistent way is work most people should do at some point in their lives, even for purposes other than vegan advocacy. It doesn't matter what is in our hearts; people can only hear us if we are able to effectively communicate what is within us via our words and demeanour.

Tailoring your message

While we're on the subject of preaching, among people who consider themselves activists, perhaps no other cliche is more often said after a speech or discussion than "Aren't we just preaching to the converted?" This treats something like veganism as a binary state, where you are vegan and saved, or you are a heathen who needs to come into the light. Veganism may be something close to a moral baseline, but it is not the end of our journey towards a healthy, ethical or fulfilled life. People shouldn't just be converted and left to their own devices; they should be continually educated, inspired, included and energised. They do need a different sort of communication, though; I've been in a room full of vegans where someone gives some version of the talk "Why you should go vegan". That is the wrong talk for that audience; people need to consider their audience and pass on the information that will best help them further along the ethical path.

I've also heard talks that seemed to rely on you already agreeing with what they said to enjoy them, or even really hear them. If you give a talk encouraging veganism to a mixed audience, it doesn't really matter if all the vegans in the room are nodding when you are saying things that the non-vegans just can't relate to. To the unconverted, you need more basic, targeted, subtle and thoughtful ways of engaging than vegan preaching. Vegans may cheer your angry preaching on from the sidelines; you might even gain a following and some groupies, but it’s probably not effective in achieving what should be your aims: to help animals. We must hold your arguments to a different, more careful standard when talking to people who don't agree with us; we must try to speak in such a way that even the people who want to disagree with your perspective can’t help but acknowledge it has merit.

The psychological disconnect

Whilst discussing perspective, it’s interesting what is considered preaching and what isn't. Generally, what people agree with is the good sort of preaching and what they disagree with is the bad sort. An example of this was when a group called The Coalition for the Protection of Racehorses erected a billboard showing a racehorse that had been injured during a race. The horse was lying down on its side, and although this wasn't made evident on the billboard, people could assume that the horse was awaiting being put to death. The activist group were soon notified by the landowner that the billboard had been taken down because people in the community were disturbed by the image of the injured horse. Compare this with the billboards featuring farm animals that litter our suburbs and roads, blights on our urban scenery that are considered commonplace and never questioned. These billboards feature detached parts of these animals, murdered while young and perfectly healthy, whose body parts have been burnt and then labelled “food”. These injunctions to consume more animals are apparently socially acceptable, whereas a billboard calling for greater compassion towards animals draws complaints and condemnation. People are happy seeing chunks of flesh of murdered animals, but they don't like to see an animal lying waiting to be murdered. Perhaps nothing could be as

clear in showing the disconnect between the food on people's plates, which people see as a disembodied product, and the lives of the animals from which that food comes. It’s not just what you see that creates your world, but also the story you tell, or choose not to tell, yourself internally about it. Is that a piece of food, or is it the burnt flesh of an intensively bred, malformed animal murdered prematurely after a terrible life? For people who eat meat, it is clearly both, but for some reason, whether it be habit, intellectual self-defense or self-interested bias, they often only see the former. Our worldview can be so hardened and habitual to us that it can be hard to even comprehend someone if they are saying something that contradicts it. Studies show us that people find it harder to pay attention to and recall images that they find psychologically discomforting. People will subconsciously avoid disturbing elements in images, as if some sub or preconscious part of the brain is filtering information before it gets into their conscious attention. People also find it harder to recall images with disturbing aspects to them. Given that what goes on in slaughterhouses and factory farms is disturbing to normal individuals, it makes sense that these psychological mechanisms will come into play. We are therefore not just trying to inform people, but trying to change their current frame of reference, often against their subconscious will. The task of advocating for animals is not just putting information out into the world; we have to help people open themselves to uncomfortable information in a way that doesn’t provoke emotional self-defence mechanisms, and that is considerate of other traumas that people might already be dealing with. None of this is easy, but it is a challenge we must accept in order to best help the animals.

If I were an animal bred in a factory farm or on my way to slaughter, I’d desperately hope someone would be preaching for me, but more importantly, I would want them to be most effectively helping me. Being right is not enough; shouting at the world in anger is probably counter-productive. The point is to change the world, to make ethical progress. People rarely change from one fact, phrase, sign, t-shirt, interaction or conversation, and will often be especially resistant to this if it is put to them in a hostile manner. As many as the thought of billions of animals in factory farms and slaughterhouses burns most vegans, as urgent as the task before us is in the face of so much suffering, we have to accept that the world is unlikely to suddenly awaken to reality tomorrow. We need to put some thought into long-term, structural strategies that involve economics, philosophy, psychology and politics. Emotions are vital in motivating us, but their power needs to be carefully harnessed by our rationality so that we are most effective.

If you want to be an effective vegan advocate, especially if you want to be a preachy vegan, you need to do the work. Read about psychology and effective behaviour change, the history of our movement and its thinkers, the arguments and justifications of the other side, the lives of farmed animals, the livestock industry’s effects on the environment, human rights and our political systems. You don’t have to know everything, indeed you should be quick to acknowledge that you don’t, but you don’t want to come off as either ill-informed or overly emotionally motivated. Like any conversation, it is important to have the facts on your side, to try to listen, seriously consider other points of view, make them feel heard and look for common ground on which to build. Keep in mind, before we judge others, that most of us haven’t always been vegan, and being vegan doesn't mean you don't have other areas to ethically improve upon.

Being strategic

There is also the question of preaching effectively, of using our emotional resources and time

to achieve the best outcome for animals. The random people you meet on a street, who walk past a protest, even your friends and family, might not be the subset of the community most open to change. There are, however, large numbers of people beyond your immediate social interactions who are actively pondering a vegan diet, or could be easily convinced to move in that direction, and these people want or need a little hand up. Finding these people and helping them, what we call "pushing on open doors", can be a much more effective and less confrontational form of activism. You can do this by things like cooking classes, vegan mentoring, introductions to plant-based diets, baketivism, and so on. I've been involved in some amazing programs we called Vegan Pledges, where groups of people were taken through a program to help them try being vegan for a month. The pledge was free for participants, and included food samples, nutrition advice, mentoring, events and group support; it was incredibly effective. You don't have to come up with all the strategies yourself; there have been so many smart activists around the world, and things they have tried, you just need to learn about and familiarise yourself with them.

When it comes to effective activism, not only don't you have to do it on your own, you probably shouldn't. If you want to make a change at a wider level, being part of an activist group, or starting one if you have to, is a way of multiplying and strengthening our individual efforts. Having a group to think about plans and campaigns with, and to implement them, means you can do more ambitious and well-thought-through things. A group benefits from having a variety of personalities, skills, knowledge, ideas and perspectives; it can also keep going when “life happens”, and people drop in and out over time. Also, people can concentrate on the things that they enjoy, such as the sort of things that attract introverts, extroverts, neurodiverse, and neurotypical people, and so on. I used to help run volunteer inductions for an Animal Liberation organisation, and if there was one thing I found hard to get across to people, it was that activism doesn’t have to be the more confrontational "go vegan" style. Small organisations need lots of different skills, from various professional services to baking, fundraising, marketing, committee membership, handy work and so on. Indeed, just turning up, doing what you say you will do, being nice to everyone, and being reliable is perhaps the best trait any volunteer can have in a group. If you really have the urge to preach, that's fine, but if you just want to help animals, there are many other ways to do so.

Speaking for them

Sometimes we refer to non-human animals as the voiceless. Many people point out that animals do speak for themselves, as they instinctively cry out against the injustices and pain that are inflicted upon them as standard practises in animal agriculture. Those cries, however, will never be heard by the consumers who pay to have these animals bred, confined and slaughtered. We have banished the slaughterhouses and factory farms well out beyond the urban environments most people live in, so the animals they eat are barely real beings to the consumers who have so much power to decide on their fate. We must help people to hear the voices of those animals; we have a duty to speak for them, indeed, even to preach for them in the right time and place. To take it upon yourself to speak for another being, though, requires a high bar of consideration. If we have to preach, we need to do it thoughtfully; we need to focus on what helps the animals and not just what we personally want to do. Just preaching because it makes us feel better to "get it out", especially if we are acting in such a way that it actively discourages people from the cause we are preaching for, is not a good thing in itself. You should be angry about the way animals are treated; other people should also be angry about it, but triggering irrational forces like anger is unpredictable and likely to backfire. I have spent time with cows, pigs, chickens, goats, ducks and other animals at sanctuaries.

When I think about how gentle most farmed animals are, how much they appreciate a kind voice and touch, it inspires me to try to embody the way they generally are in how I communicate on their behalf to others.

You may not care what other people think of you and your way of being in the world. You may even wear your prickly individualism like a badge of honour, perhaps rejecting the world before it can reject you. This may win you fans in the right social circles, but the world we are trying to change is much more vast. To be a vegan is to be part of the idea of what vegan means for the people we encounter. Like it or not, whatever identity we have, especially if we are in a minority, we will be a representative of that identity in the world. We may not choose the responsibility of defining what veganism is for other people, but it is thrust upon us every time we say we are vegan, wear a vegan shirt, or order a vegan meal. To be an effective advocate for animals, we must understand that our medium and our message are inextricably intertwined. Veganism is about compassion to all animals, humans included, so let us embody that consistently so as not to confuse that simple truth in other people's minds.